REGISTERED COMPANY NUMBER: 07556117 (England and Wales)

Report of the Trustees and

Financial Statements For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

for

Northern Ambition Academies Trust

WEDNESDAY

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COMPANIES HOUSE

Kingswood Allotts Limited, Statutory Auditor
Chartered Accountants
Sidings Court
Lakeside
Doncaster
South Yorkshire
DN4 5NU

Northern Ambition Academies Trust

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For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

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Northern Ambition Academies Trust

Reference and Administrative Details
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

MEMBERS:	A J Nicholson (resigned 23.1.2024) A Clark R Sloan M Dixon
TRUSTEES	R A Hall (Chair) E Fairhurst (Accounting Officer) (resigned 31.5.2024) S Fox (resigned 24.5.2024) S Groves K S Guy (resigned 7.1.2024) E Hayden (resigned 30.11.2023) A Latham N Wrightson (resigned 31.8.2024) B McDowell (resigned 31.8.2024)
COMPANY SECRETARY	D Walton
SENIOR MANAGEMENT TEAM:	C Eastwood (Head of School Airedale Academy) (appointed 26.5.2024) P Greenhough (Part Time Director of School Improvement & Accounting Officer) (appointed 1.11.2023) D Neal (Interim Principal Airedale Academy) (appointed 1.11.2023) (resigned 25.5.2024) D Walton (Chief Finance & Operations Officer) K McKechnie (Executive Primary Headteacher Airedale) N York (Head of Human Resources) J Chapman-Kemp (Headteacher Oyster Park Primary Academy) K Robinson (Part-Time Director of School Improvement) E Fairhurst (Chief Executive) (resigned 31.5.2024) L Proctor (Principal Airedale Academy) (resigned 31.12.2023)
REGISTERED OFFICE	Crewe Road Airedale CASTLEFORD West Yorkshire WF10 3JU
REGISTERED COMPANY NUMBER	07556117 (England and Wales)
AUDITORS	Kingswood Allotts Limited, Statutory Auditor Chartered Accountants Sidings Court Lakeside Doncaster South Yorkshire DN4 5NU
SOLICITORS	Wrigleys Solicitors 19 Cookridge Street Leeds LS2 3AG
BANKERS	Lloyds TSB Plc Wakefield Westgate Branch PO Box 1000, BX1 1LT

Report of the Trustees
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

The Trustees present their annual report together with the financial statements and auditors' report of the charitable company for the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024. The annual report serves the purposes of both a trustees' report and a directors' report under company law.

This has been a year of stability in terms of the size of the Trust, as no new schools have joined the Trust during this financial year. The Trust continues to comprise Airedale Academy (capacity 1250, NOR 1056 including sixth form), Airedale Infants School (capacity 180 plus 78 nursery places, NOR 178 plus 48 in nursery), Airedale Junior School (capacity 480 and NOR 391) and Oyster Park Primary Academy (capacity 420 plus 78 nursery places, NOR 326 plus 56 in nursery) - figures correct as at October 2023.

STRUCTURE, GOVERNANCE AND MANAGEMENT

Constitution
Northern Ambition Academies Trust (the Trust) is a company limited by guarantee and an exempt charity. The charitable company's memorandum and articles of association are the primary governing documents of the Trust.

The Trustees of Northern Ambition Academies Trust are also the directors of the charitable company for the purposes of company law. The charitable company is known as Northern Ambition Academies Trust and operates four academies: Airedale Academy, Oyster Park Primary Academy, Airedale Infant School and Airedale Junior School.

Details of the trustees who served throughout the year are included in the Reference and Administrative Details on page 1.

Members' Liability
Each member of the charitable company undertakes to contribute to the assets of the charitable company in the event of it being wound up while they are a member, or within one year after they cease to be a member, such amount as may be required, not exceeding £10, for the debts and liabilities contracted before they ceased to be a member.

Trustees' Indemnities
The Trust does not purchase separate insurance for trustees' indemnities as it buys into the Risk Protection Arrangement offered by the Department for Education, which provides appropriate cover for the trustees' liabilities.

Method of Recruitment and Appointment or Election of Trustees
Members of the Trust may appoint up to nine Directors by any process as they may determine. There must be at least two parent directors unless there are Academy Councils which include at least two parent members. In addition, the Chief Executive Officer is an ex-officio director. The directors may appoint co-opted directors. The table below gives details of the directors, which group they belong to, who is entitled to elect them and where the details of their appointment can be found in the Articles of Association.

Type	Name	Number / proportion	Appointed / elected by	Section of Articles
Chief Executive	Mrs E Fairhurst	1	Directors. Ex-officio	46b, 57, 107
Directors	R Hall S Fox S Groves K Guy A Latham B McDowell N Wrightson	Up to 19	Directors or Members. With a balance of skills and experience appropriate to the needs of the Board at the time, as identified by skills audits and gaps analysis	47, 58
Staff Directors	None	CEO only	Directors or Members.	50B, 58
Parent Directors	None as parents are represented on each governing body.	At least two unless there are at least two parent governors on each Academy Council.	Directors	53-56

The Trustees identify, through periodic audits of skills, where there are skills lacking on the Board of Trustees and seek nominations from suitably-qualified persons to fill any vacancies, and from time to time receive expressions of interest in joining the Board of Trustees, which are considered as and when vacancies arise. Priority in appointing individuals to the Board goes to those individuals with skills which are needed by the Trust, and to individuals with a link to the community of Airedale. Potential candidates for the role of trustee are interviewed by the Nominations Committee (comprising the Chief Executive and Chair of Trustees (or their representatives)), before attending a Board meeting as an observer. A recommendation is made to the trustees by the Nominations Committee regarding the appointment or otherwise of the potential trustee, and voted on by board members. Appointments are subject to satisfactory references and DBS clearance for the appointed trustee.

Trustees are subject to retirement by rotation every four years, except that this time limit shall not apply to the Chief Executive. Subject to remaining eligible to be a particular type of trustee, any trustee may be reappointed or re-elected.

Policies and Procedures Adopted for the Induction and Training of Trustees
The training and induction provided for new trustees will depend upon their existing experience, although all new trustees are required to complete a series of key modules of online training relating to academy governance provided by the NGA. Where necessary, induction will provide training on charity and educational, legal and financial matters. All trustees are offered the opportunity to visit the academies and to meet with staff and students to develop their knowledge of the phases of education being delivered within the Trust. All trustees are provided with copies of relevant policies, procedures, minutes, budgets, reports and other documents which they will need in order to discharge their responsibilities as directors and trustees.

Organisational Structure
Northern Ambition Academies Trust is a family of academies with a single shared vision, a single Board of Trustees and a single Scheme of Delegation. The Scheme of Delegation sets out the powers the Trust's committees (including Academy Councils) and executive officers may exercise on behalf of the trustees. In accordance with requirements this is published on the Trust's website www.northernambition.org.uk

Our model of governance is designed to reflect the overall responsibility of the Trust Board, the line management of Headteachers by education professionals, and the value of the local experience and understanding of Academy Councils in scrutinising the performance of their academy and its interaction with the local community.

The company has three layers of corporate governance which sit alongside two executive layers.

Corporate governance structures

Members
Members are the subscribers to the Memorandum of Association. They are the equivalent of shareholders of the company (although unlike shareholders they do not have rights of ownership of the company, or receive dividends or any other remuneration). Each member undertakes to contribute £10 to the liabilities of the company in the event of it being wound up.

Key responsibilities
- Establishing the purpose of the company
- Overseeing the achievement of the objectives of the company, acting as the 'conscience' and 'moral guardian' of the company's purpose and values
- Undertaking such legal duties reserved to members as are set out in the relevant legislation, such as changing the name of the company and amending the Articles
- Appointing other members and some of the Trustees
- Overseeing the performance of the Trustees
- Receiving and approving the company's financial accounts and annual report
- Appointing the auditors, based on the recommendation of the Risk and Audit Committee
- Committing to contribute a maximum of £10 to the debts of the company in the event of it being wound up
- Taking part in Annual General Meetings and any other General Meetings

Trust Board (sometimes called Board of Directors)
Trustees are responsible for the effective operation of the Trust and each academy. They have legal duties as company directors and charity trustees, and provide ongoing challenge and support to the executive team. The Board of Trustees is responsible for setting general policy, guiding the strategic direction of the Trust, adopting an annual plan and budget, monitoring the use of the Trust's resources, making major decisions about capital expenditure and changes to the Trust establishment, and participating in senior staff appointments.

Committees of the Board
These committees are established by the Trust Board to support and advise the trustees on the work of the Trust and its academies. The Trust Board determines the remit of each of these committees, their membership and the powers it will delegate to them.

Risk and Audit Committee
The Risk and Audit Committee is a committee of the Board. It is the role of the Risk and Audit Committee to act on behalf of the Board to monitor the risks facing the Trust and ensure that appropriate strategies are put in place to eliminate or mitigate these risks.

Resources Committee
The Resources Committee is a committee of the Board. It is the role of the Resources Committee to act on behalf of the Board to ensure value for money, to make decisions about the administration of the financial, physical and human resources of the Trust within its delegated levels and to monitor the appropriate use of resources by the Chief Executive Officer and other staff within their delegated authorities.

School Performance Committee
The School Performance Committee is a committee of the Board. It is the role of the School Performance Committee to act on behalf of the Board to provide challenge to the Trust leadership, primarily in respect of pupil performance, the quality of the school experience and execution of the School Development Plans (SDP).

Nominations Committee (as required)
The Nominations Committee is a committee of the Board. It is the role of the Nominations Committee to act on behalf of the Board to review the effectiveness of the Trust's governance, identify skills gaps or potential skills gaps in governance across the Trust and recruit or develop individuals to meet the needs of the Trust's structures.

Performance Management Committee
The Performance Management Committee is a committee of the Board. It is the role of the Performance Management Committee to act on behalf of the Board to review the performance of the Chief Executive, set appropriate targets for performance and determine pay progression and remuneration. The Trustees are supported in this process by an external body.

Academy Councils
Academy Councils are committees of the Trust Board. It is the role of the Academy Council to support the translation of the Trust's vision and mission into their own school, to ensure their academy complies with all policies and procedures established by the Trust Board or where required by legislation, to support and strengthen their academy's leadership through robust challenge and to develop links with the local community and stakeholders of the school.

Executive structures
Trust Executive Team
This group comprises the senior executive officers of the Trust, led by the CEO, and is responsible for the operational management of the Trust and its schools, including monitoring performance and ensuring the Trust's strategy and policies are translated into action across the schools. The Chief Executive is responsible for the overall day-to-day operation of the Trust and the Chief Financial Officer has financial oversight of the Trust on a day-to-day basis.

Academy Leadership Team
This group is responsible for the day-to-day running of each individual academy within the Trust, within the parameters set out by the Executive Team. Senior leaders are responsible for authorising expenditure within agreed budgets and appointing staff within the existing establishment; appointments for Headteacher posts always include at least one member of the Board of Trustees.

Arrangements for setting pay and remuneration of key management personnel
In determining the pay of the Trust's headteachers, the Trust sets an Individual School Range (ISR) of seven points for the Headteacher within the range of salaries applicable to the Headteacher group of the school. The range is determined on the basis of the school size and circumstances. Changes in responsibilities and the positioning of other members of the Leadership Group on the pay spine may be taken into consideration.

On appointment a Headteacher will normally be placed at the minimum of the range but the relevant body in the scheme of delegation may consider placing the successful candidate on a higher point if their existing salary exceeds the minimum of the ISR. The Headteacher must demonstrate sustained high quality of performance, with particular regard to leadership and management and pupil progress at the school, and will be subject to a review of performance against performance objectives, before any progression through the range will be awarded.

The relevant body may determine that payments in addition to the salary arising from the Headteacher's point on the ISR should be made in circumstances where:

- the school is a school causing concern;
- without such additional payment the Governing Body considers that the school would have substantial difficulty filling the vacant Headteacher post;
- without such additional payment the Governing Body considers the school would have substantial difficulty retaining the existing Headteacher; **or**
- the Headteacher is appointed as a temporary Headteacher of one or more additional schools.

This is provided that in each case that the relevant body has not previously taken such reason or circumstance into account when determining the ISR. However, all discretionary payments made to a Headteacher in respect of any school year must not exceed 25% of the amount which corresponds to that individual's point on their ISR for that year

In setting the remuneration of the Trust's CEO, the Trust Board will set a seven-point ISR range with reference to that which would be applicable were all pupils within the Trust contained within a single school. The pay range is set to reflect the additional responsibilities of the role of CEO over and above that of a normal Headteacher. The CEO is subject to the same performance management and pay progression arrangements as headteachers within the Trust. The CEO's performance management is undertaken by a Performance Management Committee comprising the Chair of Trustees (or nominated representative) and plus at least one other Trustee, with professional advice provided by an external adviser with expertise in education.

Remuneration for the Director of Finance and Operations and Head of Human Resources is set with reference to other leadership posts in the Trust's schools and benchmarked across similar size Trusts.

Related Parties and other Connected Charities and Organisations
The Trust works with the two other maintained schools within the Airedale pyramid - Townville Infants' School and Fairburn View Primary School - as part of a collaborative partnership in the interests of all pupils within the locality. This involves developing shared policies and protocols where this is of benefit to schools within the pyramid.

Trade Union Facility Time
Relevant union officials

Number of employees who were relevant union officials during the relevant period	Full-time equivalent employee number
4	3.40

Percentage of time spent on facility time

Percentage of time	Number of employees
0%	0
1% to 50%	3
51% to 99%	0
100%	1

Percentage of pay bill spent on facility time

Total cost of facility time	£28,546.56
Total pay bill	£9,866,786.25
Percentage of the total pay bill spent on facility time	0.29%

Paid trade union activities

Time spent on paid trade union activities as a percentage of total paid facility time hours	0%

Engagement with employees (including disabled persons)
Northern Ambition Academies Trust believes that everyone should be treated fairly and without prejudice. We believe that a non-discriminatory approach is beneficial to the working environment just as an inclusive approach is essential for the learning environment. As such, we believe that discrimination is unacceptable and recognise two fundamental principles:

- Each individual has the right to equality of opportunity, but this also brings with it the responsibility of each individual to respect those rights for others;
- The needs of one individual are not identical to those of another and we have a responsibility to both recognise the individual's needs and to respond positively to them.

Throughout our schools, regular briefings are held by the Principal/Headteacher for all staff to discuss day to day matters. Emails and the Trust's Share-point platform are also used for communication. Relevant Trust policies are consulted on with staff and unions prior to approval. Surveys of employee engagement and attitudes are normally undertaken across the Trust at least annually. All staff are invited to regular meetings to provide updates on Trust matters and a number of very successful joint INSET days have been held across the Trust.

We recognise that the success of the Trust, our pupils and staff is reliant on everyone within our workforce, and in turn the effectiveness of our workforce is reliant on, amongst other elements, health and wellbeing at work. We recognise that when employees feel supported and valued they feel able to achieve more. As such, we have developed a Trust Mental Health and Wellbeing Charter. This Charter forms part of our HR strategy and sets out our approach and commitment to mental wellbeing. As part of the Trust action plan running alongside the Charter, we operate our Wellbeing Ambassador initiative and look forward to working even more closely with staff on health and wellbeing matters.

The policy of the Trust is to support the recruitment and retention of pupils and employees with disabilities. Adaptations are made to methods of teaching and behaviour management to support those pupils with SEND.

During Trust recruitment processes, we ensure that our job adverts are accessible to all, stating clearly that we welcome applications from all sections of the community and demonstrate our equal opportunities policy. As part of our Equal Opportunities monitoring, when a disabled applicant applies for a role, we commit to making any adjustments necessary to allow them to apply for roles. These adjustments may involve using accessible interview locations and providing any other necessary aids, adaptations or equipment.

For members of staff who become disabled, our policy is to consider either reasonable adjustments to their current role or to seek alternative employment within the Trust, to ensure they remain in employment. Employees with disabilities are supported as appropriate to them, including adapting working patterns or providing specific equipment to support them in their work. Lifts, ramps and disabled toilets have been installed and the needs of disabled staff and students are considered in the design of new facilities, including the provision of adjustable workstations in specialist teaching areas where appropriate.

Engagement with suppliers, customers and others in a business relationship with the Trust
We have a detailed Stakeholder Management Plan which outlines our work with Stakeholders. Our key stakeholders are our pupils, parents/carers, staff and local communities, who are at the heart of our purpose. We are focused on providing the best possible educational experience for our pupils, helping them to achieve their goals, and adding value within our local community. Other key stakeholders are the suppliers from whom we purchase goods and services, local and national government. The Trust have been successful during 23/24 in securing funding from the DfE through Yorkshire Sport. Airedale Academy will receive an additional £10,000 for equipment to provide improved community use facilities and Oyster Park will receive £20,000 for the provision of equipment and coaching for children who wish to participate in sport activities during the holiday periods.

Pupils, parents and carers
Surveys with parents are undertaken periodically to assess their views of the organisation. Parental concerns and complaints are considered and addressed, with changes made to systems and processes where appropriate. Our Trust parent/carer forum also enables parents and carers to bring topics of relevance and importance to the table for discussion. Pupils are consulted via individual school councils and the Trust now operates a trust-wide Pupil Council from September. Academy Councils, along with some of the trustees, draw from parents with children at the Trust's schools, to ensure that these stakeholders' voices are heard at all levels within the Trust.

Suppliers
Engagement with our suppliers is limited beyond ensuring that we pay invoices from them in a timely way. However, we endeavour to use locally-based suppliers where possible and appropriate.

Community
The Trust is at the heart of our local community, with large numbers of our employees living locally, and we are mindful of the impact of our operations on the local area. Members, trustees and Academy Councillors are appointed with consideration to ensuring that the voice of the local community is represented within the organisation, along with that of employers for whom our pupils will form their future workforce. The Trust also supports a range of charitable and community activities, including fundraising for both national and local good causes.

Other Stakeholders
The trustees seek to make data available to other stakeholders as part of information provided about and by the Trust, including that required by statute on the Trust's website. We engage regularly with representatives of DfE, the RD and other government bodies.

OBJECTIVES AND ACTIVITIES

Objects and Aims

The charitable object of the Trust is to advance for the public benefit education in the United Kingdom, by establishing, maintaining, managing and developing schools which provide high quality education to students from all backgrounds by offering a broad curriculum and fostering collaboration across the Trust family of schools, other schools and the wider community.

Northern Ambition Academies Trust is the legal entity responsible for the operation and governance of all academies within the Trust. The academies within the Trust are not legal entities in their own right - like maintained schools they do not have a legal personality. This means that all the assets and liabilities of each academy run by the Trust are owned by the Trust, all contracts are held and entered into by the Trust, and all staff at the constituent academies are employed by the Trust. However, each academy has its own identity within the Northern Ambition Academies Trust family and contributes uniquely to the success of the organisation.

As a Trust:
- We believe that every child, whatever their background or circumstances, should be given the opportunity to flourish, succeed and dream.
- We believe that our schools have a duty to contribute to the improvement of our local communities and wider society.
- We believe that all schools within our Trust, irrespective of their starting points, bring something valuable to contribute to our success and the achievement of our collective goals.
- We believe in the importance of working together in the best interests of the children in our communities.

Our vision is a world where all children and young people are given the opportunity to thrive, succeed and aspire.

Children are at the centre of what we do. We are an organisation where
- every pupil will be supported and challenged to reach their potential
- we aim to provide the best possible preparation for our pupils to contribute to society and live fulfilled lives
- we look for the best in everyone and our starting point is that everyone in our organisation wants to learn and to contribute positively to their school and wider society

Our mission is for every child to leave our schools equipped with the essential skills they need to contribute effectively to society and to become well-rounded, confident, happy adults. To do this we believe in the following values and try to keep these at the heart of what we do:

Ambition
- We aim high and don't put limits on ourselves or other people;
- We are relentless in assessing our performance and seeking to continuously improve;
- We make the most of the opportunities offered to us to help us achieve our goals.

Bravery
- We try new things and see mistakes as an opportunity to learn;
- We don't shy away from tough decisions or difficult situations;
- We don't give up if things are hard.

Respect
- We think about the impact of our actions on others in the choices we make;
- We value what makes us different and believe everyone has something to contribute;
- We encourage honest, open debate and listen to constructive feedback about how to make things better.

Objectives, Strategies and Activities

The main overarching objectives for the Trust in 2023/24 were:
- To improve attendance across all schools
- Effective roll out of IT service and move to the cloud in order to support the implementation of our Digital Strategy
- Improve the effectiveness of Trust functions through the centralising and alignment of systems

The main objectives for Airedale Academy in 2023/24 (as identified in the Rapid Action Plan) were to conduct root and branch reform of:

Quality of Education
- Curriculum Intent: increasing time for literacy and numeracy development at KS3, securing adherence to the National Curriculum, increasing curriculum breadth at KS4, ensuring that activity was appropriately sequenced to secure composite knowledge (to 'know more and remember more')
- Curriculum Implementation: to secure sufficient subject-specific teachers to deliver the planned curriculum, to implement and imbed a standard lesson structure (recall, provide context, model new knowledge, practice, review, revisit), to establish the principals of planning to meet need including raising awareness of those children with additional needs
- Curriculum Impact: to make better use of assessment to track progress at KS4 and to identify knowledge gaps, to focus interventions upon addressing specific need

Behaviour and Engagement

- *To re-establish social norms:* reduce levels of defiance, peer-on-peer abuse, peer-on-staff abuse and truancy both through education and the consistent use of sanction as necessary
- To reduce rates of suspension/exclusion: introduction of structured removal, internal suspension and pre-emptive intervention, appointment of an Inclusion Manager
- Increase rates of attendance/ lower rates of persistent absenteeism: incentivise attendance and engagement using rewards and positive recognition, increase parental and community engagement opportunities

Personal Development

- Increase structure and rigor within the planned PD curriculum to provide increased focus upon British Values, protected characteristics and how students can keep themselves safe

The main objectives for Oyster Park Primary Academy in 2023/24 were:

- To further improve attainment by ensuring that all groups of pupils continue to make substantial and sustained progress
- To further develop the quality of education across the school with a focus on continually developing the curriculum so that outcomes continue to improve
- Ensure that phonics is taught to all key stage 2 pupils who are in the early stages of learning to read
- To improve the curriculum, delivery and status of non-core subjects across the school
- To further support those pupils with SEND through the development of an on-site provision

The main priorities for Airedale Junior School in 2023/24 were:

- To further improve attainment by ensuring that all groups of pupils continue to make substantial and sustained progress
- To further support those pupils with SEND through the development of an on-site provision
- To further refine the quality of teaching, learning and assessment.
- To further develop good and better attitudes to learning and behaviour
- To ensure outstanding leadership at all levels
- To ensure the quality of personal development is 'Outstanding'.

The main priorities for Airedale Infants School in 2023/24 were:

- To further improve attainment by ensuring that all groups of pupils continue to make substantial and sustained progress
- To ensure the quality of behaviour and attitudes is 'Outstanding'
- To ensure the quality of personal development is 'Outstanding'
- To further increase the % of children achieving GLD and ELD by the end of EYFS
- To further develop the quality of teaching and learning so that all lessons are consistently good or better
- To ensure leadership at all levels is at least good

Public Benefit

In setting our objectives and planning our activities the trustees have carefully considered the Charity Commission's general guidance on public benefit. The principal public benefit delivered by the Trust is the provision of a high-quality education to students within the community of Airedale, *in line with the articles of association. The direct beneficiaries of the Trust are the children and young people of Airedale,* who benefit from the education provided through the Trust. At the start of academic year 2023/24, three of the four Trust schools were graded as 'Good' in their last inspections. Airedale Infant School had been graded 'Good' at its first inspection in 2019 and Airedale Junior School had retained its 'Good' judgement in 2023 from its previous inspection in 2017. Oyster Park Primary Academy had been graded as 'Requires Improvement' in 2023 following inspections in both 2017 and 2019 that were similarly graded as 'Requires Improvement'. Whilst Airedale Academy retained a grading of 'Good' awarded in 2017, an ungraded inspection in 2022 indicated that standards had declined. This was confirmed in January 2024 when the school was re-inspected by Ofsted and the Academy was judged to be 'requiring improvement'.

The Trust continues to support the leadership team at Oyster Park with a view to ensuring that the Academy receives an improved judgement at the next Ofsted Inspection. Similarly, the Trust continues to support the leadership team at Airedale Academy with a view to stabilising the school and to improve standards and outcomes.

The Trust also generates additional public benefit through promoting involvement and engagement in education, sports and the arts in the wider community, offering facilities for the use of local residents, providing a not-for-profit school meals service across its schools and creation of local employment in an area of high socio-economic deprivation.

STRATEGIC REPORT

Achievement and performance

The start of the academic year 2023-24 saw the Trust in a good position with robust strategic plans in place for all schools and a comprehensive plan for school improvement. All schools continued to be challenged however by poor rates of pupil attendance and ongoing staff absence.

Outcomes at Oyster Park Primary in both Y1 phonics screening tests and at KS2 were hugely improved on 2022 and reflect an upward trend. Outcomes at GCSE and BTEC at Airedale Academy, however, were disappointing as the country moved back to 2019 GCSE measures. This reflects a downward trend from the last validated data for the school in 2019. 6th form outcomes remain high with an average grade of Distinction being achieved in 2023.

Trustees continue to plan strategically to establish the key priorities for the year and appropriate actions. Our communication with the RD is monthly and, during 2023/24, focused on growth opportunities for Northern Ambition Academies Trust.

The Chief Executive Officer resigned their position with immediate effect in May 2024. The resignation was accepted by Trustees and interim arrangements were made for the Accounting Officer role with the Director of School Improvement (Secondary).

Trustees entered discussions with Castleford Academy Trust (CAT), the DfE and RD regarding the possibility of Trust schools transferring across to CAT. Following formal consultation with parents, staff and governance, a resolution was passed by both Trust Boards to support the transfer. The matter was elevated for further discussion and approval at the Advisory Board. The Advisory Board approved the transfer in October 2024.

Key Performance Indicators

Primary Phase

Leaders and staff at **Oyster Park Primary Academy** have continued to work hard to address priorities identified from their inspection in October 2023.

The school has had external reviews throughout the year: Termly Read Write Inc Development Days and a 2-day Ofsted inspection on 7 & 8 October 2023.
In addition to this, there have been two 'Quality of Education' reviews led by the CEO and Primary Director of School Improvement with a focus on the Read to Write English Scheme and Curriculum development with specific focus on Geography, Science and Art, which also encompassed pupil voice and discussions with subject leaders.

Attendance from Sept 2023: Rec-Y6 = 91.6% (National 92.8%). Absence was largely due to illnesses, which is a national picture.
Persistent Absence (PA) for 2023-24 = 27.8% National PA = 20.7%)

Outcomes for pupils at the end of the Early Years Foundation Stage (EYFS), for a Good Level of Development, was 58%, which is an 8% decrease from 65% in 2023 and is 10% below National at 68%. 92% of this cohort entered EYFS provision below age related expectation in September 2023, so progress from starting points is at least 'Good' in all areas. Communication and Language: Speaking/Oracy development, Comprehension, Word *Recognition, Writing and Numeracy strands continue to be the prime priorities.*

Boys outperform Girls in 9/12 areas of the curriculum, though these differences are minimal. Of the areas where boys do not out-perform girls these are Word Recognition, Writing and Speaking.
Number is the strongest core strands for the cohort with 73% of children achieving 'Good level of development', which was same as 2023. The weakest subject areas in relation to GLD is writing with 64% of children achieving GLD - this is a continued area of focus for EYFS to further develop in 2024/25.
Non-Disadvantaged pupils are outperforming disadvantaged in 10/12 areas – Disadvantaged gender groups vary in strengths, but this needs to be a continued focus in Year 1 through focused interventions such as Phonic Champions every afternoon, further focused activities linked to provision and the on-going oracy development.

In Year 1 Phonics Screening, 70% achieved the expected standard in summer 2 2024, which is an 8% decrease from the previous phonic outcomes in 2023 of 78% and is 10% below National at 80%. The current cohort have a high proportion of SEND and complex needs who have made good progress from their starting points.
This has continued to be one of the main areas of priority for the school during 2023-24, where staff have received weekly CPD and monitoring including teaching assistants to ensure that delivery of the scheme is effective, consistent and of the highest quality. Termly development days have taken place from an external professional working alongside the Early Reading Leader, where practice has been observed and any suggestions made have been actioned. Identified 'off track' children have received extra 1:1 tuition and daily phonic champion intervention, which has ensured that phonic gap knowledge has reduced overtime for a large number of children.

This year there is no national data reporting for KS1/Year 2, this is part of the new measure to assess pupils from Reception to the end of KS2.

The Year 4 Multiplication Checker outcomes have increased significantly from 6% outcomes in 2023 to 55% of children scoring 25/25 on the test in 2024. (National 29% in 2023). 43% of disadvantaged achieved full marks which is significantly higher than national in 2023 at 18%.
The average score for the Year 4 cohort was 21.5 marks out of 25 compared to 13.3 in 2023 (National 20 marks in 2023).

Improving outcomes was a school priority for 23-24 where new systems and staff CPD were implemented, tracking and monitoring was rigorous, which has resulted in proven impact by the outcomes achieved.

Key Stage 2 outcomes for 2024 were the highest ever achieved by the school for both 'Age Related Expectations' and 'Greater Depth Standard'.

Age Related Expected Reading outcomes achieved were 74%, which have increased by 21% from 2023 and were in-line national.
Writing outcomes achieved were 70% for children achieving Age Related Expectations which were moderated by the Local Authority. This is an increase of 10% from 2023 and only 2% below national.
Maths outcomes for Age Related Expectations were 72%, which was 6% higher than outcomes in 2023 and again only 1% below National.
The combined outcomes for R, W & M was 64%, an increase of 11% from 2023 and 3% above National.

Differences in gender outcomes by the end of Key Stage 2 have narrowed across the year and compared to previous years. In reading the gap is 15%/4ch, in writing 20%/6ch and in maths 7%/3ch.
Differences in disadvantaged (28/49ch) compared to Non-disadvantaged (21/49ch) outcomes by the end of Key Stage 2 have reduced from the start of the academic year and compared to the previous year, where reading has a difference of 17%, in writing 33% which has the greatest difference and in maths 13%

Greater Depth Standard Reading outcomes achieved were 30%, which have increased by 15% from 2023 and were in-line with national.
Writing outcomes achieved were 11% for children achieving Greater Depth Standard which were moderated by the Local Authority. This is an increase of 6% from 2023 and only 2% below national.
Maths outcomes for Greater Depth Standard were 28%, which was a 15% increase on outcomes in 2023 and 4% above National.
The combined outcomes for R, W & M was 6%, an increase of 4% from 2023 and 2% below National.

Airedale Infant School leaders have continued to drive the school forward addressing the priorities outlined in the Ofsted report from November 2019. The school continues to be in an Ofsted window.

The school has had external reviews throughout the year: Termly Read Write Inc Development Days and a 2-day B11 Review on 15 & 16 November 2023.
In addition to this, there has been a 'Quality of Education' review led by the CEO and Primary Director of School Improvement with a focus on the Quality of Education in KS1.

Attendance from Sept 2023: Reception-Y2 = 92.7% (National 92.8%). Absence was largely due to illnesses, which is a national picture.
Persistent Absence for 2023-24 = 27.8% (National PA = 20.7%)

Outcomes for pupils at the end of the Early Years Foundation Stage (EYFS), for a Good Level of Development (GLD), was 60%, which is a 5% decrease from 65% in 2023 and is below National at 68%.

This still demonstrates good progress over time, as 85% of this cohort entered Reception working below Age Related Expectations across the GLD strands based on the National baseline data.

The quality of education delivered and planned provision areas continues to improve. Prime areas of learning such as word recognition, comprehension and writing continue to be a key focus for the EYFS team, as well as speech, language & communication, which is a national picture.

Girls continue to outperform boys in 11/12 areas of the curriculum. Of the areas where boys perform lower than girls by more than 15% these are Managing-Self, Self-Regulation, Fine Motor Skills and Writing.
Maths and Communication and Language are the strongest core strands for the cohort with at least 75% of children achieving 'Good level of development', which has increased from 2023. The weakest subject area in relation to GLD is writing with 67% of children achieving GLD.
Non-Disadvantaged pupils outperform Disadvantaged pupils in all areas. Writing has the greatest difference of 26% and Fine Motor Skills at 18%.
From the disadvantaged gender break down data, it is clear that it is Disadvantaged Boys who have the weakest performance overall. This needs to be a continued area of focus for EYFS to further develop in 2024/25 and that this group are monitored to ensure gaps reduce as this group enter Year 1.

Year 1 Phonics remains a strength of the school, where Phonic outcomes achieved were 80% in 2024. This is a slight decrease on the previous 5 years, but the needs of this particular cohort were complex with higher than normal SEND. The school continues to have termly reviews by an external consultant who has worked closely with the Early Reading Leader.

This year there is no national data reporting for KS1/Year 2, this is part of the new measure to assess pupils from Reception to the end of KS2.

The School Development Plan priorities address all the identified needs of the school to further improve outcomes and ensure that a secure judgement of 'Good' is achieved at the next Ofsted inspection in all areas.

Airedale Junior School had an Ofsted inspection in April 2023, where they continued to be graded as 'Good'. The leaders continue to address the priorities outlined in the Ofsted report.

The school has two 'Quality of Education' reviews from the CEO, Director of School Improvement alongside other leaders from across the Trust focusing on Maths and SPaG.

Attendance from Sept 2023: Y3-Y6 = 93.27%. (National 92.8%). Absence was largely due to illnesses, which is a national picture.
Persistent Absence for 2023-24 = 16.71% (National PA = 20.7%)

The Year 4 Multiplication Checker outcomes have decreased from 29% outcomes in 2023 to 20% of children scoring 25/25 on the test in 2024. (National 29% in 2023). 13% of disadvantaged achieved full marks which is slightly lower than national in 2023 at 18%.
The average score for the Year 4 cohort was 15.2 marks out of 25 compared to 20.2 in 2023 (National 20 marks in 2023).
Improving Maths outcomes will be a school priority for 24-25.

Age Related Expected Reading outcomes achieved were 62%, which have increased by 1% from 2023 and is 12% below national.
Writing outcomes achieved were 62% for children achieving Age Related Expectations, which have increased by 1% from 2023 and is 10% below national.
Maths outcomes for Age Related Expectations were 49%, which was 20% lower than outcomes in 2023 and 24% below National.
The combined outcomes for R, W & M was 36%, a decrease of 8% from 2023 and is 25% below National.

Differences in gender outcomes by the end of Key Stage 2 are similar to the previous year, except in maths where boys outperformed girls for the first time in several years. In reading the gap is 11%, in writing 22% and in maths boys perform stronger than girls by 7%.
Differences in Disadvantaged compared to non-disadvantaged outcomes by the end of Key Stage 2 have reduced in reading from the start of the academic year. Reading has a difference of 22%, Writing has the greatest difference at 40% and in maths the gap is 29%. Disadvantaged girls have performed weak compared to previous years especially in maths where only 3/17 achieved Age Related expectations.

Discussions between leaders and Director of School Improvement have taken place to analyse outcomes, identify specific strands where performance was weak, potential reasons and identify actions needed to ensure outcomes improve for 2024/25 at the end of Key Stage 2.

Greater Depth Standard Reading outcomes achieved were 12%, which have decreased by 4% from 2023 and 17% below national.
Writing outcomes achieved were 12% for children achieving Greater Depth Standard, which was the same as 2023 outcomes and only just below national.
Maths outcomes for Greater Depth Standard were 7%, which was a 7% decrease on outcomes in 2023 and 17% below National.
The combined outcomes for R, W & M was 4%, a decrease of 2% from 2023 and 4% below National.

Secondary Phase - Airedale Academy
At **Airedale Academy**, following the resignation of the principal in half-term one, an interim Principal and Director of School Improvement (Secondary) were appointed to undertake detailed review and to implement a comprehensive school improvement program. Initial review placed Airedale Academy at risk of being placed within and Ofsted category of concern. This was due to:

- A lack of academic progress made by children across several subjects (as outlined in the Report of the Trustees for year ending 31 August 2023)
- Significant and persistent behavioural issues involving a significant minority of children across Key Stages 3 and 4 (as reflected in suspension and permanent exclusion rates significantly above regional and national averages)
- Gaps in pupil knowledge and understanding around British Values, protected characteristics and how to keep themselves safe
- Insufficient capacity to improve due to high levels of staff absenteeism and many unfilled vacancies (particularly in key departments – Maths, Science and Foreign Languages)

An Ofsted Inspection (dated 30 and 31 January) recognized the actions taken by leaders to address challenges within the school even though it was too early to see the impact of those actions. The report accurately identified inconsistencies within the quality of teaching (including within the taught PD curriculum), the use of assessment and the application of behavioural strategies. The team assessed that Airedale Academy 'Required Improvement.'
Planned development activity continued throughout the remainder of academic year 2023/24 and into the start of 2024/25:

- The standard lesson template was introduced and embedded through sequential training, implementation, quality assurance and support
- The curriculum was remodeled for first teaching September 2025 (including the PD Curriculum and the introduction of enrichment 'Stop the Clock' and KS4 intervention days)
- A restructure was conducted of curriculum staffing including leadership roles and responsibilities
- The curriculum was fully staffed from September following a significant recruitment drive (including five Science teachers and three Language teachers)
- Behaviour protocols were rewritten and introduced and embedded through sequential training, implementation, quality assurance and support

- A behaviour support unit comprising three zones – 'Connect' (classroom removal), 'Internal Exclusion,' and 'Step Up' (proactive intervention and inclusion) – was established from September 2024 to stem the high rates of suspension and permanent exclusion at Airedale Academy
- Additional staffing was allocated to support the attendance monitoring and intervention function with the aim of reducing pupil absence (including rates of persistent absenteeism)

As intended, the actions undertaken in 2023/24 stemmed the decline in academic outcomes. Tracking systems indicate that teacher assessment and prediction at KS4 is robust and accurate (when cross-referenced with outcomes for the 2024 cohort). In 2024, Airedale Academy performed poorly when compared with regional and national comparisons. Overall Progress 8 is expected to be significantly negative and at -0.72 in-line with the validated measure from 2023 (-0.68). Attainment measures similarly remained stable from 2023 to 2024 – Grade 4 or above in English and Maths at 44% (compared with 42% in 2023), Grade 5 or above in English and Maths at 24% (compared with 23% in 2023), Attainment 8 at 33.9 (compared with 33.2 in 2023).
More positively, by the end of summer term 2024, assessment and predictions for the 2025 cohort were already tracking significantly above those for the 2024 cohort for the same period. Attainment targets have been set for each department which, should they be achieved, will secure a mean 0.5 grade improvement for each child in each subject. Planned interventions will build upon those introduced in 2023/24 and add intervention days to run alongside targeted weekly interventions identified from the half-termly Raising Attainment Group (RAG) meetings.
Whilst outcomes for the sixth form provision compare favourably with national averages, the narrow offer and the small uptake of places mean that it has not been viable to offer an intake for 2024. Consultation will be undertaken in 2024/25 regarding whether to close the post-16 provision at Airedale Academy.
A permanent Principal has been appointed to assume post from September 2024.

Going Concern
After making appropriate enquiries, the trustees have a reasonable expectation that the Trust has adequate resources to continue in operational existence for the foreseeable future. However, the accounts are to be prepared on a basis other than going concern due to the pending transfer to Castleford Multi Academy Trust, which is expected to be completed within 12 months of this report. For Further details regarding the adoption of the going concern basis can be found in the Statement of Accounting Policies.

Promoting the success of the company
The trustees have acted in accordance with their duties codified in law, which include their duty to act in the way in which they consider, in good faith, would be most likely to promote the success of the Company for the benefit of its members, stakeholders and the matters set out in section 172(1) of the Companies Act 2006. The Charities Commission has issued guidance which explains that charitable companies should take "promoting the success of the company" to mean "promoting the success of the charity to achieve its charitable purposes."

Northern Ambition Academies Trust is governed by its charitable objects. These charitable objects set out the purpose of the charity. The consequences of all decisions and activities of the charity are assessed by how they drive us towards achieving that long-term purpose, including by reference to the charity's strategy, vision and values. As an educational charity, we are accountable not only to our funders and direct beneficiaries (our pupils) but also our parents and wider community. These stakeholders support us, engage with us, and challenge us. They ensure that the decisions we make as a charity, from the ground level through to the Board, are for their benefit. We are a value driven organisation and our values mean that we are informed, shaped and powered by our determination to uphold our vision and values. Well-established involvement and consultation mechanisms, both direct (through parent and staff surveys) and indirect (through the involvement of parents and local people on our Academy Councils, Trust Board and our parent/carer Forum) ensure that decisions made by the trustees are informed by the needs of the organisation's stakeholders.

Long-term consequences of any decision
Trustees consider the consequences of any strategic decision in the long-term as part of their assessment. We aim to ensure that as an organisation we balance our income and expenditure to ensure that our organisation remains sustainable in the long term. This is balanced against the needs of our pupils, staff and other stakeholders, and the community, to ensure we are spending the funding we receive from the government in the most effective way to support our aims, and with integrity. This year this has included significant investment in the Trust's Estate and other infrastructure/facilities. The Trust has continued to be successful in attracting Condition Improvement Funding from the DfE. In the 23/24 CIF Funding cycle, the Trust were also successful in securing £1.6m for the improvement of fire safety measures at Airedale Academy. These works commenced in June 2024 and will see the improvement of fire safety measures in the Technology Block, main Upper and Lower School and also the complete remodelling of the old humanities block and includes the creation of a bespoke Inclusion suite. These works collectively provide a major improvement to the teaching and learning facilities of our pupils. During the 23/24 financial year, the completion of the Lower Heating CIF project and the removal of asbestos was also completed.

The Trust have further enhanced facilities across the Trust by providing:

- New catering equipment at Airedale Academy, Oyster Park and Airedale Juniors
- Additional fencing at Airedale Academy, Oyster Park and Airedale Infants & Juniors
- Replacing the old ICT infrastructure cabling at Airedale Infants & Juniors
- Providing additional ICT equipment at all of the Academies within the Trust
- Providing a Trust wide telephone system
- Replacing the external doors at Airedale Juniors
- Upgrading the access control systems at each of the Academies within the Trust

- Upgrading the FF&E at Airedale Academy
- Replacing blinds at Airedale Academy and Airedale Infants and Juniors
- Investing in the creation of new websites for each of the Academies within the Trust
- Replacement of external signage at Airedale Academy
- Improvements have also been made to the culture and climate of each of the academies within the Trust.

The Trust have been able to further improve facilities through securing external funding as follows:

- Oyster Park - installation of external Wi-Fi infrastructure - £10,000 funded by the DfE.
- Airedale Academy - provision of equipment to support community use - £10,000 funded by the DfE via Yorkshire Sport.
- Oyster Park - provision of equipment and coaching time to provide holiday sports activities - £20,000 funded by the DfE via Yorkshire Sport.

The Trust Board have also identified the priorities for the 24/25 financial year and these projects include:

- Replacing the Sound and Light System in the Airedale Academy Theatre
- Investing in the external playground equipment at Airedale Infants, Juniors and Oyster Park
- Improvements in the culture and climate of Airedale Infants, Juniors and Oyster Park
- Investigating the options for providing external shelters within each Academy
- Investigating the options for improving communal access to the Airedale Academy Theatre, Fitness Suite and Sports facilities.
- Continued investment in additional ICT equipment
- Investigating the options for improving recreational areas
- Continuing to submit applications for CIF Funding to improve the mechanical and electrical services within Airedale Academy Upper School, replacement of roofing and the heating system at Airedale Infants& Juniors and fire safety measures at Airedale Infants and Juniors.
- Formal commencement of community use of the Airedale Academy facilities including the Theatre, Fitness Suite and other Sports facilities.

These priorities have been discussed with the Executive Leaders at Castleford Academies Trust.

During the 2023/2024 financial year the Trust undertook a strategic review into the 6th form in light of national changes to 6th form courses. The Yr 12 recruitment process for 1 September 2024, did not provide sufficient interest or numbers for Airedale Academy to enrol students into Year 12. The existing Yr 13 has 26 students enrolled. The Trust will during 24/25 investigate the viability of the 6th form going forwards.

The interests of the company's employees
Details of how the trustees consider the interests of the organisation's employees can be found in the section Engagement with employees within this report. In addition, the Trust implemented a Wellbeing Action Plan, introduced Well Being Ambassador roles and have increased the employee engagement that takes place across the Trust. The Trust surveys staff annually and collates the results of this survey and seeks to address the issues identified. The Trust also buys into the School Wellbeing offering annually, for all its' staff who can access over 21 services of wellbeing and support.

The need to foster the company's business relationships with suppliers, customers and others
Details of how the trustees consider the interests of the organisation's other stakeholders can be found in the section Engagement with suppliers, customers and others in a business relationship with the Trust. The Trust continues to work to pay smaller suppliers on shorter credit periods, to support their cashflow. We also work closely with local companies where appropriate to support the local economy.

The impact of the company's operations on the community and the environment
Details of how the trustees consider the impact on the community can be found in the section Engagement with suppliers, customers and others in a business relationship with the Trust. Further information is also given in the section on Public Benefit.

The desirability of the company maintaining a reputation for high standards of business conduct
The Trust aims to conduct all its relationships with integrity and courtesy, and scrupulously to honour every business agreement. We subscribe to the principles of Ethical Leadership. The trustees have approved a number of policies that help to ensure the charity maintains high standards of business conduct; these include the Investment Policy, Anti-Fraud and Whistleblowing Policy, and Gifts and Hospitality Policy.

The need to act fairly as between members of the company.
All members of the Trust are treated fairly and equally, with the same access to information, the ability to directly contact trustees or the Executive, and being invited to participate in training or strategic development events; for example, all members have been kept up to date about the activities of the Trust and are routinely invited to participate in meetings and events.

All matters reserved for decision by the trustees are presented at board or committee meetings as appropriate. Trustees are briefed on any identified potential impacts and risks for our stakeholders and how they are to be managed. The trustees take these factors into account before making a final decision which together they believe is in the best interests of the Trust and its stakeholders.

STRATEGIC REPORT

Financial review

The Trust held fund balances as at 31 August 2024 of £25,000k. This comprised £1,052k of unrestricted funds, £20,841k of restricted fixed asset funds and £3,107k of restricted general funds.

The majority of the Trust's funding comes from the Department for Education (DfE) via the Education and Skills Funding Agency (ESFA) in the form of recurrent grants, the use of which is restricted to particular purposes. The grants received from the DfE and related expenditure are shown as restricted funds in the statement of financial activities.

During the year ending 31 August 2024, total expenditure (excluding depreciation and FRS102 adjustments, including assets purchased out of revenue funds) of £17,445k was covered by recurrent grant funding from the DfE plus income from other sources and reserves brought forward. The excess expenditure over income for the period (excluding restricted fixed asset funds and pension reserve) was £721k.

At 31 August 2024 the net book value of fixed assets was £20,841K. The value of fixed assets includes the value of those assets which were transferred by Wakefield MDC as part of the transfer agreement, which comprises the land and buildings for Airedale Academy and Oyster Park (which are occupied on a 125-year lease from the local authority at a peppercorn rent) plus the fixtures, fittings, furniture and equipment on the Academy site at the point of transfer. It also includes the land and buildings for Airedale Junior School and Airedale Infant School (occupied on a 125-year lease) plus the fixtures, fittings, furniture and equipment on the site at conversion. These assets have been used for the provision of education and associated support services to the pupils of the relevant academy. The significant level of fixed assets additions during the period was due to a combination of a successful bid by Airedale Academy for Condition Improvement Fund money, on window, fire safety, drainage, lower heating, and asbestos projects. The value of which has been recognised in the accounts.

The deficit in the Local Government Pension Scheme (LGPS) of NIL (2023: Surplus £597k) is recognised in the balance sheet as per the requirements of FRS102.

The Trust has continued to benefit from government funding to support recovery (post-Covid pandemic). As a Trust, we will build our catch-up/recovery and pupil premium strategy around three key strategic priorities:

- Whole-school approaches: support the quality of teaching, such as staff professional development;
- Targeted approaches: provide targeted academic support, such as tutoring targeted approaches; and
- Wider strategies: tackle non-academic barriers to success in school, such as attendance, behaviour and social and emotional support

We will be adopting a strategic approach to deploying the funding, using the tiered approach and devolving all funding to schools who must plan within the approach using an agreed Trust template. We will ensure our strategy is balanced between longer-term sustainable approaches to supporting the quality of teaching through evidence-informed professional development and shorter-term targeted interventions like tuition.

Reserves Policy

During the 23/24 financial year, the Trustees continue to operate consolidated bank accounts. Trustees have exercised caution when considering investment of reserves but did invest £1.5m in a secure deposit account in July 2024. Trustees have released reserves to support the investment and improvement in Estates, Infrastructure and facilities and have been supportive to the academies in terms of additional staffing costs that have been incurred during the 23/24 financial year with a view to improving student outcomes and improving the culture and climate within the Trust's academies.

At 31 August 2024, Northern Ambition Academies Trust held total funds of £25,000k including £1,052k in unrestricted free reserves and £3,107k in restricted GAG reserves. This is above the minimum level set by the Trust by £2,500k. A significant proportion of the funding above the minimum level set by the Trustees is designated for capital expenditure in the next five years in line with renewal and refurbishment plans, and the remainder is being held in reserve to meet emerging needs during forthcoming academic years due to predicted changes in pupil numbers and to smooth out budget fluctuations anticipated as the effects of the new National Funding Formula become clear.

At 31 August 2024 the fixed asset fund of £21,134k includes £20,782k which can only be realised from the sale of fixed assets.

Investment Policy

The trustees have adopted a cautious investment policy, the main principle of which is to safeguard the Trust's cash funds. In light of the consolidation of the Trust's bank accounts, the Trust reviewed the investment policy and placed funds on deposit in July 2024.

Principal Risks and Uncertainties

The trustees have assessed the major risks to which the Trust is exposed, in particular those relating to teaching, provision of facilities, financial and other operational areas of the academies.

Risk management is embedded in the day-to-day processes of the Trust. Systems or procedures have been established to manage risks, especially in relation to operational areas, and are regularly reviewed and updated. These include aspects such as vetting new staff and visitors, undertaking and updating risk assessments, and implementing a robust system of internal financial controls in order to minimise risk. Where significant financial risks still remain, the Trust has adequate insurance cover in place.

STRATEGIC REPORT

The key risks facing the Trust at present are:

- Recruitment and retention of staff - both teaching and support staff
- Financial - the uncertainty surrounding pay awards for teachers and support staff and whether these will be fully funded by the *Government via the National Fair Funding Formula.*
- Financial - the volatility of the energy market and the cost of energy in the mid-long term
- Financial - the impact of the 'cost of living crisis' on the cost of delivering education and the impact of the cost of maintaining and operating the Trust's academies
- Reputational - any negative Ofsted judgements received by and of the Trust's Academies in the short-mid term.
- Strategic - the impact of the above reputational risk as well as the ongoing impact of the Government's White Paper regarding small trusts
- Strategic - the risk of NAAT not aligning with the DFE's definition of a Strong Trust.

The Trust has an ongoing process of identifying and addressing risks to the business and seeks to put appropriate measures in place as new risks are identified or existing risks are reassessed.

FUNDRAISING

The Trust carries out a limited amount of fundraising, mindful of the communities within which it operates. All fundraising is undertaken at individual school level and any funds raised remain within the school which raised them, unless explicitly raised for an external organisation such as the Royal British Legion, Macmillan, Comic Relief, Children in Need, and Brain Tumour Research (all of which have been supported during 2023/24). During the year fundraising activities included bake sales, non-uniform days and the sale in school of items associated with particular charities (including poppies and red noses).

In the circumstances when fundraising is undertaken, systems and controls are in place to separate and protect funds. The Trust is mindful of its responsibilities under the Charities (Protection and Social Investment) Act 2016 and legal rules, and ensures all activities are agreed and monitored at Senior Leadership Team level in compliance with relevant legal rules. Recognised standards are applied to ensure that fundraising is open, honest and respectful, protecting the public from undue pressure to donate. The Trust does not normally work with professional fundraisers or companies who carry out fundraising on its behalf. However, in 2023/24 the Trust engaged the services of Oaks Consultancy to identify what external funding opportunities exist to support the Trust's Significant Business Case for opening an alternative provision facility at Airedale Academy, which was eventually not progressed due to a change in focus by the DfE.

Complaints are handled and monitored through the Trust's complaints procedure. During the year no complaints or issues have arisen as a result of the fundraising events.

STREAMLINED ENERGY AND CARBON REPORTING

UK Greenhouse gas emissions and energy use data for the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024:	2022/23	2023/24
Energy consumption used to calculate emissions (kWh)	2,470,924	2,363,673
Energy consumption break down (kWh) (optional):		
- gas	1,513,005	1,466,101
- electricity	953,544	891,876
- transport fuel	4,375	5,696
Scope 1 emissions in metric tonnes CO2e		
Gas consumption	277.12	268.53
Owned transport - mini-buses	3.97	4.74
Total Scope 1	281.09	273.27
Scope 2 emissions in metric tonnes CO2e		
Purchased electricity	202.47	189.37
Scope 3 emissions in metric tonnes CO2e		
Business travel in employee owned vehicles	0.40	0.95
Total gross emissions in metric tonnes CO2e	483.96	954.00
Intensity ratio Tonnes CO2e per pupil	0.240	0.476

Quantification and reporting methodology
We have followed the 2019 HM Government Environmental Reporting Guidelines. We have also used the GHG Reporting Protocol - Corporate Standard and have used the 2021 UK Government's Conversion Factors for Company Reporting.

Intensity measurement
The chosen intensity measurement ratio is total gross emissions in metric tonnes CO2e per pupil, the recommended ratio for the sector.

Measures taken to improve energy efficiency
Energy usage overall continues to fall, year on year. The Trust have introduced new boilers and heating systems at Airedale Academy, have undertaken significant building works which include increased insulation. The Trust have also a rolling programme for the replacement of lights to LED. The Trust have a number of solar panel agreements in place. There is an increased use in mileage as more staff have returned to work and are actively engaging with our community including home visits. There has been an increased usage in the use of the Trust's minibus as a result of increased cultural capital. A significant number of meetings are held virtually.

PLANS FOR FUTURE PERIODS
The overarching objectives for the trust this year are to ensure:
- Strong and Effective Leadership (including governance)
- High Performing Staff
- The Quality of Education leads to exceptionally good progress in all phases
- Develop capacity for school improvement and growth.
- A smooth transition of all Trust schools and their staff to CAT

The main priorities for ensuring rapid and sustained school improvement across all Trust schools the academic year (2024/25) are:
- Improve attendance and reduce persistent absence
- Improve the quality of provision for those children with additional needs (to ensure that identified needs are met)
- Further improve the Quality of Education to improve rates of academic progress and outcomes for children in all years (including the most vulnerable – children with SEN and in receipt of Pupil Premium funding)
- Prepare schools for Ofsted Inspection through robust and honest self-evaluation and bespoke school improvement actions
- Further develop collaborative working practices within NAAT and across the wider educational system (including CAT)

FUNDS HELD AS CUSTODIAN TRUSTEE ON BEHALF OF OTHERS
The Trust currently holds no funds on behalf of any other organisation.

STATEMENT AS TO DISCLOSURE OF INFORMATION TO AUDITORS
Insofar as the trustees are aware:
- there is no relevant information (as defined by Section 418 of the Companies Act 2006) of which the charitable company's auditors are unaware.
- *each trustee has taken all the steps that they ought to have taken as a trustee in order to make them aware of any audit information and* to establish that the charitable company's auditors are aware of that information.

Report of the trustees, incorporating a strategic report, approved by order of the board of trustees, as the company directors, on 22 January 2025 and signed on the board's behalf by:

R A Hall - Trustee

Governance Statement
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

SCOPE OF RESPONSIBILITY

As trustees, we acknowledge we have overall responsibility for ensuring that Northern Ambition Academies Trust has an effective and appropriate system of control, financial and otherwise. However such a system is designed to manage rather than eliminate the risk of failure to achieve business objectives, and can provide only reasonable and not absolute assurance against material misstatement of loss.

As trustees, we have reviewed and taken account of the guidance in DfE's Governance Handbook and competency framework for governance.

The board of trustees has delegated the day-to-day responsibility to the Director of School Improvement, as accounting officer, for ensuring financial controls conform with the requirements of both propriety and good financial management and in accordance with the requirements and responsibilities assigned to it in the funding agreement between Northern Ambition Academies Trust and the Secretary of State for Education. They are also responsible for reporting to the board of trustees any material weaknesses or breakdowns in internal control.

GOVERNANCE

The information on governance included here supplements that described in the Report of the Trustees and in the Trustees' Responsibilities Statement. The board of trustees has formally met 10 times during the year. Attendance during the year at meetings of the board of trustees was as follows:

Trustee	Meetings attended	Out of a possible
R Hall (Chair)	9	10
E Fairhurst (Accounting Officer)	6	6
S Fox	5	8
S Groves	9	10
K Guy	9	10
E Hayden	2	2
A Latham	6	10
B McDowell	9	10
N Wrightson	8	10

During 2021/22 the Trustees commissioned a Governance Review from which a Governance Development Action Plan was produced. This Action Plan includes:

- the introduction of Academy Councils (which have replaced the Local Governing Bodies), and the introduction of Academy Councillors instead of Governors.
- greater communication channels between the Trustees and the Academy Councils via a Chair's Forum
- developing greater links between Trustees and the work of individual Academies
- developing of the role of Governance Professional

The Trustees have monitored progress against this Action Plan during the 2023/24 academic year and this was assessed as part of internal scrutiny in this academic year. The output identified that thirty of thirty-one recommendations were completed with the final one in progress.

Governance reviews

The continued focus for 2024/25 will be on working with our trustees and academy councillors to ensure that they have the skills and expertise to provide effective governance across the organisation. The Trust continues to facilitate access for all trustees and academy councillors to the NGA's Learning Link materials, to support the development of knowledge and fill skills gaps, and routinely shares links to appropriate training opportunities with academy councillors and trustees. Following an SRMA review in the academic year 2023-2024 this will be developed further to ensure all levels of governance have the information required. The Trust is also in discussions with another local multi-academy trust with a view to transferring in the next academic year. This is subject to completion of due diligence and DfE approval.

Trustees receive regular overview reports providing data on the academic and financial performance of the schools and wider Trust. More detailed scrutiny of the data takes place at committee level.

Conflicts of interest
Throughout the year, the Trust has managed conflict of interest at Trust Board and Committee Meetings. Any conflicts of interest were identified at the beginning of the year (through the Annual Declarations made by Trustees and Academy Councils). Any current declarations would be reviewed and actions taken including notification to the ESFA and also by the Governance Professional/Chair ensuring that the party who had the conflict of interest did not take part in any relevant discussions/meetings.

The Resources Committee is a subcommittee of the main Board of Trustees and met seven times during the year. It is the role of the Resources Committee to act on behalf of the Board to ensure value for money, to make decisions about the administration of the financial, physical and human resources of the Trust within its delegated levels and to monitor the appropriate use of resources by the Chief Executive Officer and other staff within their delegated authorities. Attendance at the meetings in the year was as follows:

Trustee	Meetings attended	Out of a possible
R Hall	7	7
E Fairhurst (Resigned 31 May 2024)	5	5
E Hayden (Chair until 30 November 2023)	2	2
S Fox (Resigned 24 May 2024)	3	6
S Groves (Chair from 15 January 2024)	7	7
K Guy	1	1

The Risk and Audit Committee is a subcommittee of the main Board of Trustees and met four times during the year. It is the role of the Risk and Audit Committee to act on behalf of the Board to monitor the risks facing the Trust and ensure that appropriate strategies are put in place to eliminate or mitigate these risks. Attendance at the meetings in the year was as follows:

Trustee	Meetings attended	Out of a possible
S Groves	4	4
K Guy (Chair)	4	4
N Wrightson	4	4
E Fairhurst	2	2

The School Performance Committee is a subcommittee of the main Board of Trustees and met three times during the year. It is the role of the School Performance Committee to act on behalf of the Board to monitor data and outcomes from the 4 academies and ensure that appropriate strategies are put in place to achieve as desired. Attendance at the meetings in the year was as follows:

Trustee	Meetings attended	Out of a possible
E Hayden (resigned 30 November 2023)	1	1
A Latham (Chair)	1	3
B McDowell	3	3
E Fairhurst (resigned 31 May 2024)	3	3
S Groves	2	2

REVIEW OF VALUE FOR MONEY
As accounting officer, the Chief Executive has responsibility for ensuring that the Trust delivers good value in the use of public resources. The Accounting Officer understands that value for money refers to the educational and wider societal outcomes achieved in return for the taxpayer resources received.

The accounting officer considers how the Trust's use of its resources has provided good value for money during each academic year, and, reports to the Board of Trustees where value for money can be improved, including the use of benchmarking data or by using a framework where appropriate.

The accounting officer has delivered improved value for money during the year in the following ways:
- The increased centralisation of services
- Voluntary SRMA Review in May 2024
- External Review of in house Catering and Cleaning Activities in February and March 2024.
- Joint procurement exercises including the procurement of ICT infrastructure, licences, equipment and software.
- Joint procurement exercises for website re-design, telephone, professional educational service contracts, financial support software systems, compliance support software systems.
- Joint procurement of building services such as fencing, access control, external doors, external signage.
- Joint procurement of Catering equipment.
- Joint procurement of 'Evolve' Trust wide Trips and Visits system
- Joint procurement of Staff Wellbeing provision.
- Best value review of Licences including those for Finance System and Budgeting software.

Collaborative procurement has enabled the Trust to benefit from the combined purchasing power of the Academies

THE PURPOSE OF THE SYSTEM OF INTERNAL CONTROL

The system of internal control is designed to manage risk to a reasonable level rather than to eliminate all risk of failure to achieve policies, aims and objectives. It can therefore only provide reasonable and not absolute assurance of effectiveness. The system of internal control is based on an on-going process designed to identify and prioritise the risks to the achievement of the Trust's policies, aims and objectives, to evaluate the likelihood of those risks being realised and the impact should they be realised, and to manage them efficiently, effectively and economically. The system of internal control has been in place at Northern Ambition Academies Trust for the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 and up to the date of approval of the annual report and financial statements.

CAPACITY TO HANDLE RISK

The Board of Trustees has reviewed the key risks to which the Trust is exposed together with the operating, financial and compliance controls that have been implemented to mitigate those risks. The Trustees are of the view that there is a formal ongoing process for identifying, evaluating and managing the Trust's significant risks that has been in place for the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 and up to the date of approval of the annual report and financial statements. This process is regularly reviewed by the Board of Trustees.

THE RISK AND CONTROL FRAMEWORK

The Trust's system of internal control is based on a framework of regular management information and administrative procedures including the segregation of duties and a system of delegation and accountability. In particular, it includes:

- comprehensive budgeting and monitoring systems with an annual budget and periodic financial reports which are reviewed and agreed by the Board of Trustees;
- regular reviews by the Resources Committee of reports which indicate financial performance against the forecasts and of major purchase plans, capital works and expenditure programmes;
- setting targets to measure financial and other performance;
- clearly defined purchasing (asset purchase or capital investment) guidelines;
- delegation of authority and segregation of duties;
- identification and management of risks.

The Board of Trustees has considered the need for a specific internal audit function and has determined to seek internal audit support from external providers based on identified risks. The Trust was affected by the revised FRC Ethical Standard for Auditors and, following a tender process, appointed Wylie Bisset LLP to provide assurance on the effectiveness of internal financial control and the discharge of the Trust's financial responsibilities. The internal auditor's role includes giving advice on financial and other matters and performing a range of checks on the Trust's financial and other systems. In particular, the internal auditor has undertaken reviews into Fraud, Theft & Bribery controls and systems across the Trust, Purchasing and Payments, Governance and has also completed a follow up review of Management Accounts and has undertaken follow ups against any recommendations made in the previous year's Internal Scrutiny cycle.

On a regular basis, the auditor reports to the board of trustees, through the audit and risk committee on the operation of the systems of control and on the discharge of the board of trustees' financial responsibilities, and annually prepares an annual summary report to the committee outlining the areas reviewed, key findings, recommendations and conclusions to help the committee consider actions and assess year on year progress.

The auditors made several recommendations following each audit rated as high, medium and low priority. Details of the numbers of recommendations at each level are shown below, along with a benchmark figure from other similar audits undertaken by the internal auditor for comparison

			Number of Recommendations		
Area	**Trust v Benchmark**	**Overall Conclusion**	**High Priority**	**Medium Priority**	**Low Priority**
Fraud, Theft & Bribery	Northern Ambition	Substantial	-	1	2
	Benchmark			1	3
Purchases & Payments	Northern Ambition	Strong	-	-	4
	Benchmark		-	-	2
Governance Follow Up (Completed)	Northern Ambition	Strong	-	-	-
	No Benchmark Data Provided		-	-	-
Management Accounts	Northern Ambition	Strong	-	-	-
	Benchmark		-	-	2
Follow Up (Completed)	Northern Ambition	Substantial	-	3	1

Benchmarking - Wylie Bisset consider that Northern Ambition Academies Trust has a lower number of recommendations in comparison with the trusts it has been benchmarked with.

Recommendations are graded as follows:

- High - major weakness that internal audit consider needs to be brought to the attention of the Risk & Audit Committee and addressed by senior management of the Trust as a matter of urgency
- Medium - significant issue or weakness which should be addressed by the Trust as soon as possible
- Low - Minor issue or weakness reported where management may wish to consider internal audit recommendations.

Recommendations from the internal auditor are addressed as follows:

- High Priority – within one month
- Medium Priority - within three months
- Low priority - within six months

Northern Ambition Academies Trust

Governance Statement
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

REVIEW OF EFFECTIVENESS
As Accounting Officer, the Chief Executive has responsibility for reviewing the effectiveness of the system of internal control. During the year in question the review has been informed by

- the work of the internal auditor;
- the work of the external auditor;
- the school resource management self-assessment tool
- the work of the executive managers within the Trust who have responsibility for the development and maintenance of the internal control framework

The Accounting Officer has been advised of the implications of the result of their review of the system of internal control by the Audit Committee and a plan to address any weaknesses and ensure continuous improvement of the system is in place.

CONCLUSION
Based on the advice of the audit and risk committee and the accounting officer, the board of trustees is of the opinion that the charity has an adequate and effective framework for governance, risk management and control.

Approved by order of the members of the board of trustees on 22 January 2025 and signed on its behalf by:

.....
R A Hall - Trustee

.....
Mr P Greenhough - Accounting Officer

Northern Ambition Academies Trust

Statement on Regularity, Propriety and Compliance
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

As accounting officer of Northern Ambition Academies Trust I have considered my responsibility to notify the charitable company board of trustees and the Education and Skills Funding Agency (ESFA) of material irregularity, impropriety and non-compliance with terms and conditions of all funding, including for estates safety and management, under the funding agreement between the charitable company and the Secretary of State for Education. As part of my consideration I have had due regard to the requirements of the Academy Trust Handbook 2023, including responsibilities for estates safety and management.

I confirm that I and the charitable company board of trustees are able to identify any material irregular or improper use of funds by the charitable company, or material non-compliance with the terms and conditions of funding under the charitable company's funding agreement and the Academy Trust Handbook 2023.

I confirm that no instances of material irregularity, impropriety or funding non-compliance have been discovered to date. If any instances are identified after the date of this statement, these will be notified to the board of trustees and ESFA.

.....

Mr P Greenhough - Accounting Officer

Date: 22.01.2025

Northern Ambition Academies Trust

Trustees' Responsibility Statement
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

The trustees (who act as governors of Northern Ambition Academies Trust and are also the directors of the charitable company for the purposes of company law) are responsible for preparing the Report of the Trustees and the financial statements in accordance with the Academies Accounts Direction issued by the Education and Skills Funding Agency, United Kingdom Accounting Standards (United Kingdom Generally Accepted Accounting Practice) and applicable law and regulations.

Company law requires the trustees to prepare financial statements for each financial year. Under company law the trustees must not approve the financial statements unless they are satisfied that they give a true and fair view of the state of affairs of the charitable company and of the incoming resources and application of resources, including the income and expenditure, of the charitable company for that period. In preparing those financial statements, the trustees are required to

- select suitable accounting policies and then apply them consistently;
- observe the methods and principles in the Charities SORP 2019 and the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024;
- make judgements and estimates that are reasonable and prudent;
- state whether applicable UK Accounting Standards (FRS 102) have been followed, subject to any material departures disclosed and explained in the financial statements;
- prepare the financial statements on the going concern basis unless it is inappropriate to presume that the charitable company will continue in business.

The trustees are responsible for keeping adequate accounting records that are sufficient to show and explain the charitable company's transactions and disclose with reasonable accuracy at any time the financial position of the charitable company and to enable them to ensure that the financial statements comply with the Companies Act 2006. They are also responsible for safeguarding the assets of the charitable company and hence for taking reasonable steps for the prevention and detection of fraud and other irregularities.

The trustees are responsible for ensuring that in its conduct and operation the charitable company applies financial and other controls, which conform with the requirements both of propriety and of good financial management. They are also responsible for ensuring grants received from the ESFA/DfE have been applied for the purposes intended.

The trustees are responsible for the maintenance and integrity of the corporate and financial information included on the charitable company's website. Legislation in the United Kingdom governing the preparation and dissemination of financial statements may differ from legislation in other jurisdictions.

Approved by order of the members of the board of trustees on 22 January 2025 *and signed on its behalf by:*

.....

R A Hall - Trustee

Report of the Independent Auditors to the Members of Northern Ambition Academies Trust

Opinion

We have audited the financial statements of Northern Ambition Academies Trust (the 'charitable company') for the year ended 31 August 2024 which comprise the Statement of Financial Activities, the Balance Sheet, the Cash Flow Statement and notes to the financial statements, including a summary of significant accounting policies. The financial reporting framework that has been applied in their preparation is applicable law, United Kingdom Accounting Standards (United Kingdom Generally Accepted Accounting Practice) and the Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024 issued by the Education and Skills Funding Agency (ESFA).

In our opinion the financial statements:

- give a true and fair view of the state of the charitable company's affairs as at 31 August 2024 and of its incoming resources and application of resources, including its income and expenditure, for the year then ended;
- have been properly prepared in accordance with United Kingdom Generally Accepted Accounting Practice;
- have been prepared in accordance with the requirements of the Companies Act 2006; and
- have been prepared in accordance with the Charities SORP 2019 and Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024.

Basis for opinion

We conducted our audit in accordance with International Standards on Auditing (UK) (ISAs (UK)) and applicable law. Our responsibilities under those standards are further described in the Auditors' responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements section of our report. We are independent of the charitable company in accordance with the ethical requirements that are relevant to our audit of the financial statements in the UK, including the FRC's Ethical Standard, and we have fulfilled our other ethical responsibilities in accordance with these requirements. We believe that the audit evidence we have obtained is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our opinion.

Emphasis of Matter- Conclusions relating to going concern

We draw attention to note 2 in the Financial Statements which explain that the operations of the school are expected to be transferred to another Multi-Academy Trust within 12 months of the date of this audit report. The trustees therefore do not consider it to be appropriate to adopt the going concern basis in preparing the financial statements. Accordingly, the financial statements have been prepared on a basis other than going concern as described in the note. Our opinion is not qualified in respect of the matter.

Other information

The trustees are responsible for the other information. The other information comprises the information included in the Annual Report, other than the financial statements and our Report of the Independent Auditors thereon.

Our opinion on the financial statements does not cover the other information and, except to the extent otherwise explicitly stated in our report, we do not express any form of assurance conclusion thereon.

In connection with our audit of the financial statements, our responsibility is to read the other information and, in doing so, consider whether the other information is materially inconsistent with the financial statements or our knowledge obtained in the audit or otherwise appears to be materially misstated. If we identify such material inconsistencies or apparent material misstatements, we are required to determine whether this gives rise to a material misstatement in the financial statements themselves. If, based on the work we have performed, we conclude that there is a material misstatement of this other information, we are required to report that fact. We have nothing to report in this regard.

Opinions on other matters prescribed by the Companies Act 2006

In our opinion, based on the work undertaken in the course of the audit:

- the information given in the Report of the Trustees for the financial year for which the financial statements are prepared is consistent with the financial statements; and
- the Report of the Trustees has been prepared in accordance with applicable legal requirements.

Matters on which we are required to report by exception

In the light of the knowledge and understanding of the charitable company and its environment obtained in the course of the audit, we have not identified material misstatements in the Report of the Trustees.

We have nothing to report in respect of the following matters where the Companies Act 2006 requires us to report to you if, in our opinion:

- adequate accounting records have not been kept or returns adequate for our audit have not been received from branches not visited by us; or
- the financial statements are not in agreement with the accounting records and returns; or
- certain disclosures of trustees' remuneration specified by law are not made; or
- we have not received all the information and explanations we require for our audit.

Responsibilities of trustees

As explained more fully in the Trustees' Responsibilities Statement, the trustees (who are also the directors of the charitable company for the purposes of company law) are responsible for the preparation of the financial statements and for being satisfied that they give a true and fair view, and for such internal control as the trustees determine is necessary to enable the preparation of financial statements that are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error.

In preparing the financial statements, the trustees are responsible for assessing the charitable company's ability to continue as a going concern, disclosing, as applicable, matters related to going concern and using the going concern basis of accounting unless the trustees either intend to liquidate the charitable company or to cease operations, or have no realistic alternative but to do so.

Report of the Independent Auditors to the Members of Northern Ambition Academies Trust

Our responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements

Our objectives are to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements as a whole are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error, and to issue a Report of the Independent Auditors that includes our opinion. Reasonable assurance is a high level of assurance, but is not a guarantee that an audit conducted in accordance with ISAs (UK) will always detect a material misstatement when it exists. Misstatements can arise from fraud or error and are considered material if, individually or in the aggregate, they could reasonably be expected to influence the economic decisions of users taken on the basis of these financial statements.

Irregularities, including fraud, are instances of non-compliance with laws and regulations. We design procedures in line with our responsibilities, outlined above, to detect material misstatements in respect of irregularities, including fraud. The specific procedures for this engagement and the extent to which our procedures are capable of detecting irregularities, including fraud is detailed below:

- Enquiry of management and those charged with governance around actual and potential litigation and claims;
- Enquiry of management and review of correspondence to identify any instances of non-compliance with laws and regulations;
- Review of minutes of trustees' meetings.
- Reviewing financial statement disclosures and testing to supporting documentation to assess compliance with applicable laws and regulations
- Performing audit work over the risk of management override of controls, including testing of journal entries and other adjustments for appropriateness, evaluating the business rationale of significant transactions outside the normal course of business, reviewing accounting estimates for bias and reviewing management assumptions and judgements.

Because of the inherent limitations of an audit, there is a risk that we will not detect all irregularities, including those leading to a material misstatement in the financial statements or non-compliance with regulation. This risk increases the more that compliance with a law or regulation is removed from the events and transactions reflected in the financial statements, as we will be less likely to become aware of instances of non-compliance. The risk is also greater regarding irregularities occurring due to fraud rather than error, as fraud involves intentional concealment, forgery, collusion, omission or misrepresentation.

A further description of our responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements is located on the Financial Reporting Council's website at www.frc.org.uk/auditorsresponsibilities. This description forms part of our Report of the Independent Auditors.

Use of our report

This report is made solely to the charitable company's members, as a body, in accordance with Chapter 3 of Part 16 of the Companies Act 2006. Our audit work has been undertaken so that we might state to the charitable company's members those matters we are required to state to them in an auditors' report and for no other purpose. To the fullest extent permitted by law, we do not accept or assume responsibility to anyone other than the charitable company and the charitable company's members as a body, for our audit work, for this report, or for the opinions we have formed.

Kingswood Allotts Ltd

Mark Garrison BCom FCA DChA (Senior Statutory Auditor)
for and on behalf of Kingswood Allotts Limited, Statutory Auditor
Chartered Accountants
Sidings Court
Lakeside
Doncaster
South Yorkshire
DN4 5NU

Date: 27/01/2025

Independent Reporting Accountant's Assurance Report on Regularity to Northern Ambition Academies Trust and the Education and Skills Funding Agency

In accordance with the terms of our engagement letter dated 17 August 2022 and further to the requirements of the Education and Skills Funding Agency (ESFA), as included in the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024, we have carried out an engagement to obtain limited assurance about whether the expenditure disbursed and income received by Northern Ambition Academies Trust during the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 have been applied to the purposes identified by Parliament and the financial transactions conform to the authorities which govern them.

This report is made solely to Northern Ambition Academies Trust and the ESFA in accordance with the terms of our engagement letter. Our work has been undertaken so that we might state to Northern Ambition Academies Trust and the ESFA those matters we are required to state in a report and for no other purpose. To the fullest extent permitted by law, we do not accept or assume responsibility to anyone other than Northern Ambition Academies Trust and the ESFA, for our work, for this report, or for the conclusion we have formed.

Respective responsibilities of Northern Ambition Academies Trust's accounting officer and the reporting accountant
The accounting officer is responsible, under the requirements of Northern Ambition Academies Trust's funding agreement with the Secretary of State for Education dated 21 March 2011 and the Academy Trust Handbook, extant from 1 September 2023, for ensuring that expenditure disbursed and income received is applied for the purposes intended by Parliament and the financial transactions conform to the authorities which govern them.

Our responsibilities for this engagement are established in the United Kingdom by our profession's ethical guidance and are to obtain limited assurance and report in accordance with our engagement letter and the requirements of the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024. We report to you whether anything has come to our attention in carrying out our work which suggests that in all material respects, expenditure disbursed and income received during the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 have not been applied to purposes intended by Parliament or that the financial transactions do not conform to the authorities which govern them.

Approach
We conducted our engagement in accordance with the Framework and Guide for External Auditors and Reporting Accountants of Academy Trusts issued by the ESFA. We performed a limited assurance engagement as defined in our engagement letter.

The objective of a limited assurance engagement is to perform such procedures as to obtain information and explanations in order to provide us with sufficient appropriate evidence to express a negative conclusion on regularity.

A limited assurance engagement is more limited in scope than a reasonable assurance engagement and consequently does not enable us to obtain assurance that we would become aware of all significant matters that might be identified in a reasonable assurance engagement. Accordingly, we do not express a positive opinion.

Our engagement includes examination, on a test basis, of evidence relevant to the regularity and propriety of the charitable company's income and expenditure.

The work undertaken to draw to our conclusion includes:

- Enquiry of officers of the academy
- Review and testing of income and expenditure for compliance with the funding and other agreements, the Academy Trust Handbook and the academy's system of controls
- Examination of relevant documents
- Review of the activities carried out by the academy
- Review of the delegated authorities set out in the Academy Trust Handbook
- Review of governance arrangements in accordance with the Academy Trust Handbook

Conclusion
In the course of our work, nothing has come to our attention which suggests that in all material respects the expenditure disbursed and income received during the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 has not been applied to purposes intended by Parliament and the financial transactions do not conform to the authorities which govern them.

Kingswood Allotts Ltd

Kingswood Allotts Limited
Chartered Accountants
Reporting Accountant
Sidings Court
Lakeside
Doncaster
South Yorkshire
DN4 5NU

Date: 27/01/2025

Northern Ambition Academies Trust

Statement of Financial Activities
(Incorporating an Income and Expenditure Account)
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

	Notes	Unrestricted fund £'000	Restricted funds £'000	Fixed Asset Fund £'000	2024 Total funds £'000	2023 Total funds £'000
INCOME AND ENDOWMENTS FROM						
Donations and capital grants	3	-	-	1,683	1,683	2,039
Charitable activities						
Funding for the academy's educational operations	4	344	14,376	-	14,720	14,322
Other trading activities	5	93	92	-	185	243
Investment income	6	8	-	-	8	19
Total		445	14,468	1,683	16,596	16,623
EXPENDITURE ON						
Raising funds	8	-	5	-	5	13
Charitable activities						
Academy's educational operations	9	581	14,412	2,943	17,936	16,030
Total		581	14,417	2,943	17,941	16,043
NET INCOME/(EXPENDITURE)		(136)	51	(1,260)	(1,345)	580
Transfers between funds	22	-	(556)	556	-	-
Other recognised gains/(losses)						
Actuarial gains/(losses) on defined benefit schemes		-	(677)	-	(677)	1,753
Net movement in funds		(136)	(1,182)	(704)	(2,022)	2,333
RECONCILIATION OF FUNDS						
Total funds brought forward		1,188	4,289	21,545	27,022	24,689
TOTAL FUNDS CARRIED FORWARD		1,052	3,107	20,841	25,000	27,022

The notes form part of these financial statements

Northern Ambition Academies Trust (Registered number: 07556117)

Balance Sheet
31 August 2024

	Notes	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
FIXED ASSETS			
Tangible assets	14	20,841	21,206
CURRENT ASSETS			
Stocks	15	12	12
Debtors	16	2,144	1,515
Cash at bank and in hand		3,979	6,210
		6,135	7,737
CREDITORS			
Amounts falling due within one year	17	(1,926)	(2,518)
NET CURRENT ASSETS		4,209	5,219
TOTAL ASSETS LESS CURRENT LIABILITIES		25,050	26,425
CREDITORS			
Amounts falling due after more than one year	18	(50)	-
PENSION ASSET	23	-	597
NET ASSETS		25,000	27,022
FUNDS	22		
Restricted funds:			
General Restricted fund		3,107	3,692
Fixed Asset Fund		20,841	21,545
Pension reserve		-	597
		23,948	25,836
Unrestricted funds:			
General fund		1,052	1,188
TOTAL FUNDS		25,000	27,022

The financial statements were approved by the Board of Trustees and authorised for issue on 22 January 2025 and were signed on its behalf by:

R A Hall - Trustee

The notes form part of these financial statements

Northern Ambition Academies Trust

Cash Flow Statement
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

	Notes	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Cash flows from operating activities			
Cash generated from operations	1	(3,152)	(165)
Net cash used in operating activities		(3,152)	(165)
Cash flows from investing activities			
Purchase of tangible fixed assets		(767)	(829)
Capital grants from DfE/EFA		1,680	1,227
Interest received		8	19
Net cash provided by investing activities		921	417
Change in cash and cash equivalents in the reporting period		(2,231)	252
Cash and cash equivalents at the beginning of the reporting period		6,210	5,958
Cash and cash equivalents at the end of the reporting period		3,979	6,210

The notes form part of these financial statements

Notes to the Cash Flow Statement
For The Year Ended 31 August 2024

1. RECONCILIATION OF NET (EXPENDITURE)/INCOME TO NET CASH FLOW FROM OPERATING ACTIVITIES

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Net (expenditure)/income for the reporting period (as per the Statement of Financial Activities)	(1,345)	580
Adjustments for:		
Depreciation charges	1,132	1,281
Capital grants from DfE/ESFA	(1,683)	(1,920)
Interest received	(8)	(19)
Decrease in stocks	-	16
Increase in debtors	(629)	(233)
Decrease in creditors	(541)	(122)
Difference between pension charge and cash contributions	(78)	252
Net cash used in operations	(3,152)	(165)

2. ANALYSIS OF CHANGES IN NET FUNDS

	At 1.9.23 £'000	Cash flow £'000	At 31.8.24 £'000
Net cash			
Cash at bank and in hand	6,210	(2,231)	3,979
	6,210	(2,231)	3,979
Debt			
Debts falling due after 1 year	-	(50)	(50)
	-	(50)	(50)
Total	6,210	(2,281)	3,929

The notes form part of these financial statements

1. STATEMENT OF ACCOUNTING POLICIES

A summary of the principal accounting policies adopted (which have been applied consistently, except where noted), judgements and key sources of estimation uncertainty, is set out below.

2. ACCOUNTING POLICIES

Basis of preparing the financial statements
The financial statements of the charitable company, which is a public benefit entity under FRS 102, have been prepared in accordance with the Charities SORP (FRS 102) 'Accounting and Reporting by Charities: Statement of Recommended Practice applicable to charities preparing their accounts in accordance with the Financial Reporting Standard applicable in the UK and Republic of Ireland (FRS 102) (effective 1 January 2019)', Financial Reporting Standard 102 'The Financial Reporting Standard applicable in the UK and Republic of Ireland', the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024 issued by the ESFA, the Charities Act 2011 and the Companies Act 2006. The financial statements have been prepared under the historical cost convention.

Northern Ambition Academies Trust meets the definition of a public benefit entity under FRS 102.

Going concern
The trustees assess whether the use of going concern is appropriate i.e. whether there are any material uncertainties related to events or conditions that may cast significant doubt on the ability of the company to continue as a going concern. The trustees make this assessment in respect of a period of one year from the date of authorisation for issue of the financial statements.

It is expected within the next 12 months, from the date of the balance sheet, the operations of Northern Ambition Academies Trust will be transferred to Castleford Academy Trust. All assets and liabilities will be transferred over upon completion of the transfer and the trusts' activities will cease. The financial statements have therefore been prepared on a basis other than going concern, however no material adjustments are required as a result of ceasing to apply the going concern basis.

Income
All income is recognised in the Statement of Financial Activities once the charity has entitlement to the funds, it is probable that the income will be received and the amount can be measured reliably.

Grants
Grants are included in the Statement of Financial Activities on a receivable basis. The balance of income received for specific purposes but not expended during the period is shown in the relevant funds on the balance sheet. Where income is received in advance of meeting any performance-related conditions there is not unconditional entitlement to the income and its recognition is deferred and included in creditors as deferred income until the performance-related conditions are met. Where entitlement occurs before income is received, the income is accrued.

General Annual Grant is recognised in full in the Statement of Financial Activities in the year for which it is receivable and any abatement in respect of the period is deducted from income and recognised as a liability.

Capital grants are recognised in full when there is an unconditional entitlement to the grant. Unspent amounts of capital grants are reflected in the balance sheet in the restricted fixed asset fund. Capital grants are recognised when there is entitlement and are not deferred over the life of the asset on which they are expended.

Donations
Donations are recognised on a receivable basis (where there are no performance related conditions), where it is probable that the income will be received and the amount can be measured reliably.

Other income
Other income including the hire of facilities, is recognised in the period it is receivable and to the extent the charity has provided the goods or services.

Donated fixed assets
Where the donated good is a fixed asset it is measured at fair value, unless it is impractical to measure this reliably, in which case the cost of the item to the donor should be used. The gain is recognised as income from donations and a corresponding amount is included in the appropriate fixed asset category and depreciated over the useful economic life in accordance with the charity's accounting policies.

Expenditure
Liabilities are recognised as expenditure as soon as there is a legal or constructive obligation committing the charity to that expenditure, it is probable that a transfer of economic benefits will be required in settlement and the amount of the obligation can be measured reliably. Expenditure is accounted for on an accruals basis and has been classified under headings that aggregate all cost related to the category. Where costs cannot be directly attributed to particular headings they have been allocated to activities on a basis consistent with the use of resources.

continued...

2. ACCOUNTING POLICIES - continued

Expenditure

All resources expended are inclusive of irrecoverable VAT.

Raising funds
Raising funds includes all expenditure incurred by the charity to raise funds for its charitable purposes and includes costs of all fundraising activities, events and non-charitable trading.

Charitable activities
Costs of charitable activities are incurred on the charity's educational operations, including support costs and costs relating to the governance of the charity apportioned to charitable activities.

Tangible fixed assets
Assets costing £1,000 or more are capitalised as tangible fixed assets and are carried at cost, net of depreciation and any provision for impairment.

Where tangible fixed assets have been acquired with the aid of specific grants, either from the government or from the private sector, they are included in the Balance Sheet at cost and depreciated over their expected useful economic life. The related grants are credited to a restricted fixed asset fund in the Statement of Financial Activities and carried forward in the Balance Sheet. Depreciation on such assets is charged to the restricted fixed asset fund in the Statement of Financial Activities so as to reduce the fund over the useful economic life of the related asset on a basis consistent with the academy trust's depreciation policy.

Depreciation is provided on all tangible fixed assets other than freehold land and assets under construction, at rates calculated to write off the cost of each asset on a straight-line basis over its expected useful life, as follows:

Long leasehold land	straight line over 125 years
Long leasehold buildings	2% straight line
Fixtures, fittings and equipment	10% straight line
ICT equipment	33% straight line

Assets in the course of construction are included at cost. Depreciation on these assets is not charged until they are brought into use.

A review for impairment of a fixed asset is carried out if events or changes in circumstances indicate that the carrying value of any fixed asset may not be recoverable. Shortfalls between the carrying value of fixed assets and their recoverable amounts are recognised as impairments. Impairment losses are recognised in the Statement of Financial Activities.

Financial instruments
The academy trust only holds basic financial instruments as defined by FRS102. The financial assets and financial liabilities of the academy trust and their measurement basis are as follows:

Financial assets - trade and other debtors are basic financial instruments and are debt instruments measured at amortised cost as detailed in note 16. Prepayments are not financial instruments.

Cash at bank - is classified as a basic financial instrument and is measured at face value.

Financial liabilities - trade creditors, accruals and other creditors are financial instruments, and are measured at amortised cost as detailed in note 17. Taxation and social security are not included in the financial instruments disclosure definition. Deferred income is not deemed to be a financial liability, as the cash settlement has already taken place and there is an obligation to deliver services rather than cash or another financial instrument.

Stocks
Unsold uniforms, other educational items for resale to students, theatre refreshments and frozen and tinned catering stocks are valued at the lower of cost or net realisable value.

Taxation
The academy trust is considered to pass the tests set out in Paragraph 1 Schedule 6 of the Finance Act 2010 and therefore it meets the definition of a charitable company for UK corporation tax purposes.

Accordingly, the academy trust is potentially exempt from taxation in respect of income or capital gains received within categories covered by part 11, chapter 3 of the Corporation Tax Act 2010 or Section 256 of the Taxation of Chargeable Gains Act 1992, to the extent that such income or gains are applied exclusively to charitable purposes.

continued...

2. ACCOUNTING POLICIES - continued

Fund accounting
Unrestricted income funds represent those resources which may be used towards meeting any of the charitable objectives of the academy trust at the discretion of the trustees.

Restricted fixed asset funds are resources which are to be applied to specific capital purposes imposed by funders where the asset acquired or created is held for a specific purpose.

Restricted general funds comprise all other restricted funds received with restrictions imposed by the funder/donor and include grants from the The Department for Education Group.

Pension costs and other post-retirement benefits
Retirement benefits to employees of the academy trust are provided by the Teachers' Pension Scheme ('TPS') and the Local Government Pension Scheme ('LGPS'). These are defined benefit schemes.

The TPS is an unfunded scheme and contributions are calculated so as to spread the cost of pensions over employees' working lives with the academy trust in such a way that the pension cost is a substantially level percentage of current and future pensionable payroll. The contributions are determined by the Government Actuary on the basis of quadrennial valuations using a prospective unit credit method. TPS is an unfunded multi-employer scheme with no underlying assets to assign between employers. Consequently the TPS is treated as a defined contribution scheme for accounting purposes and the contributions recognised in the period to which they relate.

The LGPS is a funded multi-employer scheme and the assets are held separately from those of the academy trust in separate trustee administered funds. Pension scheme assets are measured at fair value and liabilities are measured on an actuarial basis using the projected unit credit method and discounted at a rate equivalent to the current rate of return on a high quality corporate bond of equivalent term and currency to the liabilities. The actuarial valuations are obtained at least triennially and are updated at each balance sheet date. The amounts charged to net income / (expenditure) are the current service costs and the costs of scheme introductions, benefit changes, settlements and curtailments. They are included as part of staff costs as incurred. Net interest on the net defined benefit liability/asset is also recognised in the Statement of Financial Activities and comprises the interest cost on the defined benefit obligation and interest income on the scheme assets, calculated by multiplying the fair value of the scheme assets at the beginning of the period by the rate used to discount the benefit obligations. The difference between the interest income on the scheme assets and the actual return on the scheme assets is recognised in other recognised gains and losses.

Actuarial gains and losses are recognised immediately in other recognised gains and losses.

Under FRS102 a pension scheme surplus should only be recognised to the extent that the surplus can be recovered through reduced future contributions or through refunds from the plan.

Liabilities
Liabilities are recognised when there is an obligation at the balance sheet date as a result of a past event, it is probable that a transfer of economic benefit will be required in settlement, and the amount of the settlement can be estimated reliably. Liabilities are recognised at the amount that the multi academy trust anticipates it will pay to settle the debt or the amount it has received as advanced payments for the goods or services it must provide.

Redundancy and termination payments are recognised when there is an obligation to make the payment and the amount can be estimated reliably.

Provisions
Provisions are recognised when the academy trust has an obligation at the reporting date as a result of a past event which it is probable will result in the transfer of economic benefits and the obligation can be estimated reliably.

Provisions are measured at the best estimate of the amounts required to settle the obligation. Where the effect of the time value of money is material, the provision is based on the present value of those amounts, discounted at the pre-tax discount rate that reflects the risks specific to the liability. The unwinding of the discount is recognised within interest payable and similar charges.

Leased Assets
Rentals under operating leases are charged on a straight line basis over the lease term.

Critical accounting estimates and areas of judgement
Estimates and judgements are continually evaluated and are based on historical experience and other factors, including expectations of future events that are believed to be reasonable under the circumstances.

continued...

2. ACCOUNTING POLICIES - continued

Critical accounting estimates and assumptions

Liabilities
The multi academy trust makes estimates and assumptions concerning the future. The resulting accounting estimates and assumptions will, by definition, seldom equal the related actual results. The estimates and assumptions that have a significant risk of causing a material adjustment to the carrying amounts of assets and liabilities within the next financial year are discussed below.

The present value of the Local Government Pension Scheme defined benefit liability depends on a number of factors that are determined on an actuarial basis using a variety of assumptions. The assumptions used in determining net cost (income) for pensions include the discount rate. Any changes in these assumptions, which are disclosed in the Pension and Similar Obligations note, will impact the carrying amount of the pension liability. Furthermore a roll forward approach which projects results from the latest full actuarial valuation performed at 31 March 2022 has been used by the actuary in valuing the pensions liability at 31 August 2024. Any differences between the figures derived from the roll forward approach and a full actuarial valuation would impact on the carrying amount of the pension liability.

There is a large actuarial loss this year due to the pension surplus being restricted to Nil.

The detailed assumptions for this and the prior year are disclosed in note 23.

3. DONATIONS AND CAPITAL GRANTS

	Unrestricted funds £'000	Restricted funds £'000	2024 Total funds £'000	2023 Total funds £'000
Grants	-	1,683	1,683	2,039

Grants received, included in the above, are as follows:

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Capital Grants	1,683	1,920
Local authority grants	-	119
	1,683	2,039

4. FUNDING FOR THE ACADEMY'S EDUCATIONAL OPERATIONS

	Unrestricted funds £'000	Restricted funds £'000	2024 Total funds £'000	2023 Total funds £'000
DfE/ESFA grants				
General Annual Grant(GAG)	-	11,357	11,357	11,281
Other DfE/EFSA grant				
Pupil Premium	-	1,028	1,028	1,005
Other DfE ESFA Grants	-	1,012	1,012	953
16-19 Funding	-	210	210	-
	-	13,607	13,607	13,239
Other Government grants				
Local authority grants	-	19	19	32
Special Educational Projects	-	314	314	273
Other Grants	-	328	328	281
	-	661	661	586
Other income from the academy's educational operations	344	108	452	497
	344	14,376	14,720	14,322

continued...

5. OTHER TRADING ACTIVITIES

	Unrestricted funds £'000	Restricted funds £'000	2024 Total funds £'000	2023 Total funds £'000
Hire of facilities	-	-	-	5
Books, uniforms etc	-	1	1	-
Sundry income	93	91	184	238
	93	92	185	243

6. INVESTMENT INCOME

	Unrestricted funds £'000	Restricted funds £'000	2024 Total funds £'000	2023 Total funds £'000
Interest	8	-	8	19

7. EXPENDITURE

	Staff costs £'000	Non-pay expenditure Premises £'000	Non-pay expenditure Other costs £'000	2024 Total £'000	2023 Total £'000
Raising funds					
Costs incurred by trading for a fundraising purpose					
Direct costs	-	-	5	5	13
Charitable activities					
Academy's educational operations					
Direct costs	8,776	799	1,297	10,872	10,273
Allocated support costs	3,491	969	2,604	7,064	5,757
	12,267	1,768	3,906	17,941	16,043

Net income/(expenditure) is stated after charging/(crediting):

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Auditors' remuneration	18	16
Other non-audit services	8	7
Depreciation - owned assets	1,132	1,282
Operating leases - Others	19	23

continued...

8. RAISING FUNDS

Costs incurred by trading for a fundraising purpose

	Unrestricted funds £'000	Restricted funds £'000	2024 Total funds £'000	2023 Total funds £'000
Other costs	-	5	5	13

9. CHARITABLE ACTIVITIES - ACADEMY'S EDUCATIONAL OPERATIONS

	Unrestricted funds £'000	Restricted funds £'000	2024 Total funds £'000	2023 Total funds £'000
Direct costs	66	10,806	10,872	10,273
Support costs	516	6,548	7,064	5,757
	582	17,354	17,936	16,030

	2024 Total £'000	2023 Total £'000
Analysis of support costs		
Support staff costs	3,491	3,118
Technology costs	10	20
Premises costs	969	1,104
Legal costs - other	192	181
Other support costs	2,376	1,311
Governance costs	26	23
Total support costs	7,064	5,757

10. STAFF COSTS

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Wages and salaries	8,554	8,069
Social security costs	808	703
Operating costs of defined benefit pension schemes	1,778	1,902
	11,140	10,674
Supply teacher costs	874	503
Staff restructuring costs	138	-
Other staff costs	115	84
	12,267	11,261

Staff restructuring costs comprise:		
Severance payments	138	-

The academy trust paid 3 severance payments in the year; disclosed in the following bands:

0 - £25,000	1
£25,001 - £50,000	1
£50,001 - £100,000	1
£100,001 - £150,000	-
£150,000+	-

continued...

10. STAFF COSTS - continued

Included in staff restructuring costs are special severance payments totalling £63,347 (2023: £nil). Individually, the payments were: £49,000 and £14,347.

The average number of persons (including senior management team) employed by the charitable company during the year was as follows:

	2024	2023
Teachers and educational support staff	173	167
Administration and support	125	142
Management	21	19
	319	328

The number of employees whose employee benefits (excluding employer pension costs) exceeded £60,000 was:

	2024	2023
£60,001 - £70,000	8	3
£70,001 - £80,000	4	4
£80,001 - £90,000	4	1
£100,000 - £110,000	1	1
	17	9

The key management personnel of the multi academy trust comprise the trustees and the senior management team as listed on page 1. The total amount of employee benefits (including employer pension contributions and employer national insurance contributions and staff severance payments) received by key management personnel for their services to the academy trust was £805.803 (2023: £693,650).

11. RELATED PARTY TRANSACTIONS - TRUSTEES' REMUNERATION AND EXPENSES

One or more trustees has been paid remuneration or has received other benefits from employment with the academy trust.

The Chief Executive Officer and staff trustees only receive remuneration in respect of services they provide undertaking the roles of Chief Executive Officer and staff, and not in respect of their services as trustees. Other trustees did not receive any payments, other than expenses, from the academy in respect of their role as trustees. The value of trustees' remuneration was as follows:

E Fairhurst - (staff trustee)
Remuneration, including severance pay: £175,000 - £180,000 (2023: £105,000 - £110,000)
Employer's pension contributions: £10,000 - £15,000 (2023: £25,000 - £30,000)

12. TRUSTEES' AND OFFICERS' INSURANCE

The academy trust has opted into the Department for Education's risk protection arrangement (RPA), an alternative to insurance where UK government funds cover losses that arise. This scheme protects trustees and officers from claims arising from negligent acts, errors or omissions occurring whilst on academy business, and provides cover up to £10,000,000. It is not possible to quantify the trustees and officers indemnity element from the overall cost of the RPA scheme membership.

continued...

13. COMPARATIVES FOR THE STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL ACTIVITIES

	Unrestricted fund £'000	Restricted funds £'000	Fixed Asset Fund £'000	Total funds £'000
INCOME AND ENDOWMENTS FROM				
Donations and capital grants	-	-	2,039	2,039
Charitable activities				
Funding for the academy's educational operations	328	13,994	-	14,322
Other trading activities	110	116	17	243
Investment income	19	-	-	19
Total	457	14,110	2,056	16,623
EXPENDITURE ON				
Raising funds	-	13	-	13
Charitable activities				
Academy's educational operations	486	13,513	2,031	16,030
Total	486	13,526	2,031	16,043
NET INCOME/(EXPENDITURE)	(29)	584	25	580
Transfers between funds	-	(1,035)	1,035	-
Other recognised gains/(losses)				
Actuarial gains on defined benefit schemes	-	1,753	-	1,753
Net movement in funds	(29)	1,302	1,060	2,333
RECONCILIATION OF FUNDS				
Total funds brought forward	1,217	2,987	20,485	24,689
TOTAL FUNDS CARRIED FORWARD	1,188	4,289	21,545	27,022

14. TANGIBLE FIXED ASSETS

	Leasehold land and buildings £'000	Furniture and fixtures £'000	Plant and equipment £'000	Totals £'000
COST				
At 1 September 2023	28,699	1,266	1,845	31,810
Additions	585	70	112	767
At 31 August 2024	29,284	1,336	1,957	32,577
DEPRECIATION				
At 1 September 2023	8,235	980	1,389	10,604
Charge for year	800	80	252	1,132
At 31 August 2024	9,035	1,060	1,641	11,736
NET BOOK VALUE				
At 31 August 2024	20,249	276	316	20,841
At 31 August 2023	20,464	286	456	21,206

continued...

15. STOCKS

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Stock	12	12

16. DEBTORS: AMOUNTS FALLING DUE WITHIN ONE YEAR

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Trade debtors	51	20
VAT recoverable	175	297
Prepayments and accrued income	1,918	1,198
	2,144	1,515

17. CREDITORS: AMOUNTS FALLING DUE WITHIN ONE YEAR

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Trade creditors	752	1,391
Taxation and social security	167	184
Other creditors	242	245
Accruals and deferred income	765	698
	1,926	2,518

Deferred income	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Deferred Income at 1 September 2023	154	177
Resources deferred in the year	176	154
Amounts released from previous years	(154)	(177)
Deferred Income at 31 August 2024	176	154

This relates to amounts received prior to 31 August 2024 for periods spanning the year end recognised on a pro rata basis.

18. CREDITORS: AMOUNTS FALLING DUE AFTER MORE THAN ONE YEAR

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Other loans (see note 19)	50	-

Loan of £50,000 (2023: £nil) from DFE CIF Loan repayable in 8 years time with an interest rate of 3.2%

19. LOANS

An analysis of the maturity of loans is given below:

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Amounts falling due between two and five years:		
Other loans - 2-5 years	50	-

continued...

20. MEMBERS' LIABILITY

Each member of the charitable company undertakes to contribute to the assets of the company in the event of it being wound up while he/she is a member, or within one year after he/she ceases to be a member, such amount as may be required, not exceeding £10 for the debts and liabilities contracted before he/she ceases to be a member.

21. ANALYSIS OF NET ASSETS BETWEEN FUNDS

				2024
	Unrestricted fund	Restricted funds	Fixed Asset Fund	Total funds
	£'000	£'000	£'000	£'000
Fixed assets	-	-	20,841	20,841
Current assets	1,052	4,239	844	6,135
Current liabilities	-	(1,082)	(844)	(1,926)
Long term liabilities	-	(50)	-	(50)
Pension asset	-	-	-	-
	1,052	3,107	20,841	25,000

Comparative information in respect of the preceding period is as follows:

				2023
	Unrestricted fund	Restricted funds	Fixed Asset Fund	Total funds
	£'000	£'000	£'000	£'000
Fixed assets	-	-	21,206	21,206
Current assets	1,188	5,008	1,541	7,737
Current liabilities	-	(1,316)	(1,202)	(2,518)
Pension asset	-	597	-	597
	1,188	4,289	21,545	27,022

continued...

22. MOVEMENT IN FUNDS

2024	Balance 01.09.23 £000	Incoming Resources £000	Resourced Expended £000	Gains, losses and transfers £000	Balance 31.08.24 £000
Restricted general funds					
General annual grant (GAG)	3,692	11,357	(11,386)	(556)	3,107
Pupil Premium	-	1,028	(1,028)	-	-
Pension Grant					
Other DfE / ESFA grants	-	1,012	(1,012)	-	-
16-19 Funding	-	210	(210)	-	-
Other Grants	-	661	(661)	-	-
Other Revenue	-	200	(200)	-	-
Restricted pension reserve	597	-	80	(677)	-
	4,289	14,468	(14,417)	(1,233)	3,107
Restricted fixed asset funds					
Assets transferred on conversion	14,376	-	(651)	-	13,725
Donated assets	115	-	(37)	-	78
DfE grants	4,148	1,683	(2,050)	-	3,781
Other capital expenditure	2,906		(205)	556	3,257
	21,545	1,683	(2,943)	556	20,841
Total restricted funds	25,834	16,151	(17,360)	(677)	23,948
Unrestricted funds	1,188	445	(581)	-	1,052
Total funds	27,022	16,596	(17,941)	(677)	25,000

The specific purposes for which the funds are to be applied are as follows:
The restricted general funds relate to grants receivable from the DfE, ESFA and other sources towards the operating activities of the Academy Trust. These include GAG, Pupil Premium, Early Years funding, SEN and other grants. Under the funding agreement with the Secretary of State, the Academy Trust was not subject to a limit on the amount of GAG that it could carry forward at 31 August 2024.

The restricted fixed assets funds represent the net book values of donated fixed assets and assets purchased from DfE/ESFA/other government grants, which have to be held for the continuing use of the Academy Trust, together with any unspent capital funds.
The transfers out of GAG to restricted fixed asset funds relate to capital expenditure made in excess of funds received in the year.

2023	Balance 01.09.22 £000	Incoming Resources £000	Resourced Expended £000	Gains, losses and transfers £000	Balance 31.08.23 £000
Restricted general funds					
General annual grant (GAG)	3,891	11,281	(10,445)	(1,035)	3,692
Pupil Premium	-	1,005	(1,005)	-	-
Pension grant	-	-	-	-	-
Covid grants	-	-	-	-	-
Other DfE / ESFA grants	-	953	(953)	-	-
Other grants	-	586	(586)	-	-
Other revenue	-	285	(285)	-	-
Restricted pension reserve	(904)	-	(252)	1,753	597
	2,987	14,110	(13,526)	718	4,289
Restricted fixed asset funds					
Assets transferred on conversion	15,033	-	(657)	-	14,376
Donated assets	190	-	(75)	-	115
DfE grants	3,246	1,937	(1,035)	-	4,148
Other capital expenditure	2,016	119	(264)	1,035	2,906
	20,485	2,056	(2,031)	1,035	21,545
Total restricted funds	23,472	16,166	(15,557)	1,753	25,834

continued...

22. MOVEMENT IN FUNDS - continued

Unrestricted funds	1,217	457	(486)	-	1,188
Total funds	24,689	16,623	(16,043)	1,753	27,022

Fund balances at 31 August 2024 were allocated as follows:

	2024 £000	2023 £000
Airedale Academy	-	-
Airedale Infants Academy	-	-
Airedale Juniors Academy	-	-
Castleford Oyster Park Primary Academy	-	-
Central Services	4,159	4,880
Total before fixed assets and pension reserve	4,159	4,880
Restricted fixed asset fund	20,841	21,545
Pension reserve	-	597
	25,000	27,022

From 01 September 2022 the trust decided to pool its reserves and manage the trust funds via the Central Services, hence the nil closing balances per individual academy.

Analysis of academies by cost

	Teaching & Educational Support Staff £000	**Other Support staff £000**	**Educational Supplies £000**	**Other Costs (excluding depreciation) £000**	**2024 Total £000**	**2023 Total £000**
Airedale Academy	4,414	1,917	500	911	7,742	7,261
Airedale Infants Academy	745	250	39	110	1,144	1,144
Airedale Juniors Academy	1,647	389	74	275	2,385	2,385
Castleford Oyster Park Primary Academy	1,639	335	70	286	2,330	2,108
Central Services	331	600	19	2,257	3,207	1,858
Academy Trust	8,776	3,491	702	3,839	16,808	14,756

23. PENSION AND SIMILAR OBLIGATIONS

The academy trust's employees belong to two principal pension schemes: the Teachers' Pension Scheme England and Wales (TPS) for academic and related staff; and the Local Government Pension Scheme (LGPS) for non-teaching staff, which is managed by West Yorkshire Pension Fund. Both are multi-employer defined benefit schemes.

The latest actuarial valuation of the TPS related to the period ended 31 March 2020 and of the LGPS 31 March 2022.

Contributions amounting to £211,007 were payable to the schemes at 31 August 2024 (2023: £221,789) and are included within creditors.

Teachers' pension scheme

The Teachers' Pension Scheme (TPS) is a statutory, contributory, defined benefit scheme, governed by the Teachers' Pension Scheme Regulations 2014. Membership is automatic for teachers in academies. All teachers have the option to opt-out of the TPS following enrolment.

The TPS is an unfunded scheme to which both the member and employer makes contributions, as a percentage of salary - these contributions are credited to the Exchequer. Retirement and other pension benefits are paid by public funds provided by Parliament.

continued...

23. **PENSION AND SIMILAR OBLIGATIONS - continued**

Valuation of the teachers' pension scheme

The Government Actuary, using normal actuarial principles, conducts a formal actuarial review of the TPS in accordance with the Public Service Pensions (Valuations and Employer Cost Cap) Directions 2014 published by HM Treasury every 4 years. The aim of the review is to ensure scheme costs are recognised and managed appropriately and the review specifies the level of future contributions.

Actuarial scheme valuations are dependent on assumptions about the value of future costs, design of benefits and many other factors. The latest actuarial valuation of the TPS was carried out as at 31 March 2020. The valuation report was published by the Department for Education on 27 October 2023, with the SCAPE rate, set by HMT, applying a notional investment return based on 1.7% above the rate of CPI. The key elements of the valuation and subsequent consultation are:

- Employer contribution rates set at 28.68% of pensionable pay (including a 0.08% administration levy). This is an increase of 5% in employer contributions and the cost control result is such that no change in member benefits is needed.
- Total scheme liabilities (pensions currently in payment and the estimated cost of future benefits) for service to the effective date of £262,000 million and notional assets (estimated future contributions together with the notional investments held at the valuation date) of £222,200 million, giving a notional past service deficit of £39,800 million.

The result of this valuation will be implemented from 1 April 2024. The next valuation result is due to be implemented from 1 April 2028.

The employer's pension costs paid to TPS in the period amounted to £1,238 (2023 - £1,083).

A copy of the valuation report and supporting documentation is on the Teachers' Pensions website.

Under the definitions set out in FRS 102, the TPS is an unfunded multi-employer pension scheme. The charity is unable to identify its share of the underlying assets and liabilities of the plan. Accordingly, the charity has taken advantage of the exemption in FRS 102 and has accounted for its contributions to the scheme as if it were a defined contribution scheme. The charity has set out above the information available on the scheme.

Local government pension scheme

The LGPS is a funded defined benefit pension scheme, with the assets held in separate trustee-administered funds. The total contribution made for the year ended 31 August 2024 was £792,000 (2023: £752,000), of which employer's contributions totalled £594,000 (2023: £564,000) and employees' contributions totalled £198,000 (2023 £188,000). The agreed contribution rates for future years are 15.8 per cent for employers and between 5.5 and 11.4 per cent for employees.

Parliament has agreed, at the request of the Secretary of State for Education, to a guarantee that, in the event of academy closure, outstanding Local Government Pension Scheme liabilities would be met by the Department for Education. The guarantee came into force on 18 July 2013 and on 21 July 2022, the Department for Education reaffirmed its commitment to the guarantee, with a parliamentary minute published on GOV.UK
The amounts recognised in the Balance Sheet are as follows:

	Defined benefit pension plans	
	2024	2023
	£'000	£'000
Present value of funded obligations	(15,946)	(13,452)
Fair value of plan assets	15,946	14,049
	-	597
Present value of unfunded obligations	-	-
Surplus	-	597
Net asset	-	597

continued...

23. PENSION AND SIMILAR OBLIGATIONS - continued

The amounts recognised in the Statement of Financial Activities are as follows:

	Defined benefit pension plans	
	2024	2023
	£'000	£'000
Current service cost	560	790
Net interest cost	(46)	26
Past service cost	-	-
	514	816
Actual return on plan assets	1,542	498

Changes in the present value of the defined benefit obligation are as follows:

	Defined benefit pension plans	
	2024	2023
	£'000	£'000
Opening at 1 september	13,452	14,049
Current service cost	560	790
Employee contributions	198	188
Interest cost	680	573
Actuarial (gain) / loss	1,493	(1,802)
Benefits paid	(437)	(346)
	15,946	13,452

Changes in the fair value of scheme assets are as follows:

	Defined benefit pension plans	
	2024	2023
	£'000	£'000
Opening at 1 september	14,049	13,145
Employer contributions	594	564
Employee contributions	198	188
Interest on assets	726	547
Actuarial gain / (loss)	816	(49)
Benefits paid	(437)	(346)
	15,946	14,049

The amounts recognised in other recognised gains and losses are as follows:

	Defined benefit pension plans	
	2024	2023
	£'000	£'000
Actuarial gains/(losses)	(677)	1,753
	(677)	1,753

continued...

23. PENSION AND SIMILAR OBLIGATIONS - continued

The major categories of scheme assets as amounts of total scheme assets are as follows:

	Defined benefit pension plans	
	2024	2023
	£'000	£'000
Equities	12,644	11,253
Property	431	464
Government Bonds	1,403	1,040
Other Bonds	638	632
Cash	431	548
Other	399	112
	15,946	14,049

Principal actuarial assumptions at the Balance Sheet date (expressed as weighted averages):

	2024	2023
Rate of increase in salaries	3.75%	3.85%
Discount rate for scheme liabilities	4.90%	5.10%
Inflation assumption (CPI)	2.50%	2.60%
Rate of increase in pensions	2.50%	2.60%
Rate of revaluation of pension accounts	2.50%	2.60%

The current mortality assumptions include sufficient allowance for future improvements in mortality rates. The assumed life expectations on retirement age 65 are:

	2024	2023
Retiring today		
Males	20.8	21
Females	24	24.1
Retiring in 20 years		
Males	21.7	22.2
Females	24.7	25.1

Sensitivity analysis

	2024	2023
	£'000	£'000
Discount rate +0.1%	287	269
Discount rate -0.1%	301	269
Mortality assumption - 1 year increase	359	336
Mortality assumption - 1 year decrease	359	336
CPI rate +0.1%	43	40
CPI rate -0.1%	43	40

24. CONTINGENT LIABILITIES

The trust is affected by the Harpur v Brazel case, in which the Supreme Court ruled that employees permanently contracted to work only part of the year, do not have a reduced holiday entitlement, and holiday pay should be calculated based on average pay, ignoring weeks where there are no earnings.

The trust is likely to have an additional liability in respect of term-time only or 'zero hours' staff, where holiday pay has been calculated and paid based on days worked rather than full holiday entitlement, but has been unable to accurately quantify the likely amount at this stage.

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25. CAPITAL COMMITMENTS

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Contracted but not provided for in the financial statements	996	966

26. LONG-TERM COMMITMENTS, INCLUDING OPERATING LEASES

Minimum lease payments under non-cancellable operating leases fall due as follows:

	2024 £'000	2023 £'000
Within one year	21	18
Between one and five years	24	1
	45	19

27. RELATED PARTY DISCLOSURES

Owing to the nature of the academy trust and the composition of the board of trustees being drawn from local public and private sector organisations, transactions may take place with organisations in which the trustees have an interest. All transactions involving such organisations are conducted in accordance with the requirements of the Academy Trust Handbook, including notifying the ESFA of all transactions made on or after 1 April 2019 and obtaining their approval where required, and with the academy trust's financial regulations and normal procurement procedures relating to connected and related party transactions. The following related party transactions took place in the financial period.

Expenditure Related Party Transactions

Trustees' remuneration and expenses as already disclosed in note 11.

J Hall, spouse of R Hall, chair of trustees, is employed by the academy trust as a teacher and SENCo. J Hall's appointment was made in open competition and R Hall was not involved in the decision making process regarding appointment. J Hall is paid within the normal pay scale for her role and received no special treatment as a result of her relationship to a trustee.

S Kemp, spouse of J Chapman-Kemp, a member of the trust senior leadership team, is employed by the academy trust as a teacher of maths. S Kemp's appointment was made in open competition and J Chapman-Kemp was not involved in the decision making process regarding appointment. S Kemp is paid within the normal pay scale for his role and received no special treatment as a result of his relationship to a trustee.

28. CENTRAL SERVICES

The academy trust has provided the following central services to its academies during the year:

- Human Resources
- Financial Resources
- Accountancy services
- Recruitment and Contracts services
- Payroll services
- IT related services
- Catering services
- Capital expenditure
- Educational consultancy
- Procurement
- Other services as arising

Previously, the trust charged for these services on the following basis:

- a flat 5% of GAG funding per academy
- the academies' share of any cost savings brought about by being able to negotiate as a trust

For the year ended 31 August 2024 and going forward the amounts charged were calculated after producing zero based budgets and charging any excess amounts back to the academy trust.

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28. CENTRAL SERVICES - continued

The amounts charged during the year were as follows:

	2024	2023
	£'000	£'000
Airedale Academy	427	337
Oyster Park Primary Academy	129	85
Airedale Infants Academy	1	44
Airedale Juniors Academy	265	98
	822	564